TRUEANON

Episode 220: Marathon Men (Part 1)

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with Brace & Liz
guests Ben Howard, Howie

Transcribed with Whisper and pyannote, then proofread. Speaker labels are automatic and may contain mistakes.

BRACE 0:00

Dateline, Boston, a car parked in the Harvard Yard with a— I can't do the accent anymore. These people are faking it. That's a fake accent. You know, they're all just— they're lying about that shit.

LIZ 0:13

Where does it even come from? No one answered that. No one— no one commented, no one emailed, no one messaged. Anytime we ask a question on this show— I'm not asking. It's not for you to answer. It's all rhetorical. Everything that is done on this show is rhetorical.

BRACE 0:28

I— when I ask a question, I'm— I'm putting out, and this goes for my— everything in my life, I'm putting it out there to God. If God wants to provide, if I want to walk down the street and an abandoned book blows open with large enough type to the exact page that tells me what— what's up with— can't they wash their pussies in the sink? Like, I will, like— I was telling you about that guy. Right? What? I will talk about this after.

Liz, we get a lot of letters. So many. And, I mean, thankfully I did hand out your address to several of our fans and put them on a lot of unofficial forums and gave it to our street team. And so I know that you get a ton of mail. Too much. And it seems like every time we open one of these letters, there's another one asking, when are you going to do an episode about Boston?

LIZ 1:44
Everyone is only asking us to do an episode about Boston, not an event that's happened in Boston, but just, hey, Boston, what's up with that? It's like, hey, can I hear your guys' take on Boston? Yeah, hey, Boston, what's up with that?

BRACE 2:02
Exactly, which is the town's motto, coincidentally, something that Liz and I learned in our research on Boston. Liz and I have been living in Beantown for the past three and a half years to research this episode and really get a feel from it. And one thing that I noticed is whenever I get my Blue Apron subscription in the mail with the clam chowder fixings, I'm like, how am I even going to cook this? I only have a saucepan and a microwave. And Liz, that's when I thought about something. I need a pressure cooker. Oh, of course you need a pressure cooker. Who doesn't have a pressure cooker? Well, I'll tell you, some Macy's in the Boston area seem to be sold out. So this episode is sponsored by Fagor Pressure Cookers, which you can purchase at Macy's. My name is Brace.

LIZ 2:49
I'm Liz. Hello, everyone. We are, of course, joined by our producer Young Chomsky, and this is TrueAnon. Hello.

BRACE 2:58
Hello. What if I did podcast voice forever? Hey.

LIZ 2:59
I thought you were— it was like gonna get stuck. Like, you know when you're a kid and your mom's like, don't keep your face all wonky— wait, like wonky like that— it'll get stuck? Like, what if you got stuck in podcast ad voice?

BRACE 2:59
Hey, hey, I'm Brace.com.

LIZ 2:59
Hey, hey, I'm Liz. Doesn't life sort of feel like a pressure cooker? In those instances, you have BetterHelp. I can't do it as well as you. You get the good, like— like, I don't know, like soy— like, I don't know.

BRACE 3:29
Any of you nasty hoes want to come back to my studio apartment and roll around on the Casper with me? The Casper—

LIZ 3:39
Wait, why don't you just run into, like, a Coindexter giggle—

BRACE 3:47
Any fucked up looking skanks want to come back?

LIZ 3:49
Alright, alright, alright, alright. Worlds are colliding. You just want to get into the Casper? It's water cooled. I feel like Coindexter can't have a capsule.

BRACE 3:59
We would love it when you have a water-cooled mattress. Water? What? It's like a water-cooled mattress. It's like using water-based technology

to cool the mattress out. You overclocked that mattress. Yeah, yeah, yeah. It's like if you get it running too hot. But maybe that's not a problem for you guys.

LIZ 4:19

Oh my God.

BRACE 4:19

That's just— hello, everyone. Welcome to TrueAnon. Hello. We're back. Wait, we're not back. This is the first one. Yeah, this is the first one. Liz, what are we talking about today?

LIZ 4:26

This is— we've been planning and thinking and planning some more about how to do this series for a long time, but we are finally doing a series on the Boston Marathon bombing, which happened in 2013.

BRACE 4:49

Yes. For those of you who don't know— I gotta say, in the canon of terrorist attacks that there was in the last decade worldwide, frankly, doesn't rank very high. You know, there was a lot of bigger ones. I mean, if you're in Boston, yes, but I'm talking just, like, worldwide. Like, if you live in, like, France or whatever, you're probably— I don't know. Yeah, what is this? This is like one-tenth of a Bataclan. But, like, you know, in— in America it was a pretty big and still remains in some degree a pretty big deal. So let's give the top of the line: what happened? What are we talking about?

5:25

LIZ

So the Boston bombing happened on April 15th, 2013 in Boston, Marathon Monday, as it's called, which is the day of the annual Boston Marathon. There were two bombs set off on Boylston, which is in the downtown area where the marathon finish line was, in succession, I think about 12 or 14 seconds apart from one another. And total chaos ensued. There were, I believe, like over 260 casualties. A lot of people lost limbs, three people died. It was a really gruesome, grisly, like, horrific scene. I mean, I think a lot of people have probably seen some of the photographs in the immediate aftermath. It was just any— if you— if you hear, like, you know, read testimony or hear stories from some of the people who were kind of thrown into the situation, just being first responders, just a total chaotic, horrific, horrific scene.

6:29

BRACE

Yeah, I mean, that was sort of, I think, one of the big things that came out of it was a ton of images of this, like, carnage that— that sort of ensued from it. For the next— there was this sort of sense that terrorism had returned over a decade after 9/11. There was this another major attack on U.S. soil. There was a sort of interregnum where there was unknown who did it, and then there was a very well-publicized and pretty spectacular manhunt and chase to catch the two brothers who the government claimed did it.

One of the brothers died during that and the other brother was arrested and sort of became a media flashpoint.

Liz, you remember the Rolling Stone cover that had, like, emo Dzhokhar on it? Dzhokhar's the name of the younger brother.

LIZ 7:23
Oh yeah, very controversial. People got very mad about it. Although I gotta say, in the words of the kids— iconic.

BRACE 7:26
Yeah, iconic. Yeah, he was serving, honestly. He was giving and serving in that. But became sort of, like, a media kind of touchstone. There was Boston Strong, there was a Marky Mark movie, there was a Jake Gyllenhaal movie. You know, it was— it was sort of like this— it was— it was really portrayed in this way that, like, we turned it around. We had this awful attack and— and— and now we're actually stronger from it. Like, they'll never— we're bloodied but unbowed. But what we understood as the public wasn't fully the true story and the real story of what actually went down.

LIZ 8:03
Yeah. And it also seems like maybe there's a lot of unanswered questions about what happened here. I think the kind of— when people jog their memory of, like, what happened there— I mean, it's been what, nine years? So almost 10 years, we'll say. Let's round up.

BRACE 8:19
You know what? 10th year anniversary. Why not?

8:20

LIZ

Yeah, fuck it. You know what? They could be listening next year. And to that I say, actually, if you are, it's the 11th anniversary. Exactly. See what I mean? Time is a construct. But— and yeah, so when people, like, jog their memory and they're trying to think, okay, what was the story here? It was two brothers— you might remember they were Chechen, but you certainly remember they were Muslim— who were radicalized at some point in their life and set off bombs in Boston, you know, in the name of jihad, basically. Yeah, yeah, I mean, I think that's kind of what the popular imaginary is. And maybe there's some, you know, some people who remember, oh, there was kind of some weird stuff about the story. But that's the sort of, like— I mean, I would say the Snopes version has something to do with that.

9:09

BRACE

Yes. I just realized we should call this episode something really annoying, like "Dzhokhar Tsarnaev in the Public Imaginary" or whatever, like a really academic title. Call it, like, "Marathon Spaces: Dzhokhar Tsarnaev and the Public Imagination." But yeah, and it was kind of like— I mean, as we talk about actually towards the end of this episode, there was a mystery about who did it and if they'd strike again, and if there was all these sort of fairly sensible questions to ask right after a terrorist attack that all seemed to be kind of summed up with the arrest of the younger brother and the death of the older brother.

9:48

LIZ

Yes. And then there was a very highly publicized trial that came after, and very controversial trial, where the younger brother, Dzhokhar, who sometimes is referred to as Jahar, by the way, and we flip back and forth between that two, but just to keep you on your toes—

10:07

BRACE

Kind of depends on what vibe he's serving, honestly, what he's giving.

10:10

LIZ

Yeah, absolutely. Let's see. No, the trial— you know, the trial was held in Boston, which was very controversial. And the federal government, the under— you know, Eric Holder was the attorney general— they sought the death penalty. So it was a death penalty case. He was tried for 30 charges. One of them, I think that the one charge that carried the death penalty was the weapons of mass destruction resulting in death. And then after he was convicted, he— there was a kind of lengthy appeals process where his defense— I mean, that's what, you know, they— that's kind of how it goes. So they— his defense began a lengthy appeals process. It went to the higher circuit court, which— or the court of appeals, which ended up vacating the capital sentences that he received. The feds then appealed that, and it went all the way to the Supreme Court. And then just March of this— this year, which I guess now we're back in 2022. So, okay, this year, just a month ago, the Supreme Court in a 6-3 ruling reinstated the death penalty for Dzhokhar Tsarnaev for his role in the bombings at the Boston

Marathon.

This was what Justice Clarence Thomas—he wrote the majority opinion. He said, "Dzhokhar Tsarnaev committed heinous crimes. The Sixth Amendment nonetheless guaranteed him a fair trial before an impartial jury. He received one." And if I may, what our book presupposes is that he didn't.

So I think in order to kind of lay out that case, we have done a couple of things here. One, we've got a lot of hours of tape for everyone to listen to. But also we've reached out to some friends, some friends from Beantown, some brothers from Beantown to help us. You might even say some brothers from Beantown.

BRACE 12:07

They're Irish.

LIZ 12:09

To help us on our quest for the truth and kind of break down this case. I think in this episode, what we want to do, what we need to do is kind of go through pretty bit by bit the timeline of the actual events of the bombing, where the brothers then went after that, how the local PD got involved, how the FBI got involved, and the kind of manhunt and the chaos that came out of that and went on through the rest of the week.

And then the next two episodes, we're really going to be focusing on kind of the facts that come to light after the events of the bombing and some of the activities of both the brothers, but particularly Tamerlan, the older brother, and maybe his, let's say, interesting connections with some of our old friends in DC and the agencies

that live there.

BRACE 13:07

Well, with that being said, let's— I'm trying to remember anything about the movie Boondock Saints. Let's put on our trench coats, take out our Desert Eagles, pose for the picture that is in the movie poster, and then do the rest of the things that they do in the movie, The Boondock Saints, and let's hit the brother button and get into the quad brother mode. So Young Chomsky, push the brother lever to the max, baby, because we're going to brother heaven.

Beantown. Boston. The Harvard by the sea. The city goes by many names, including even The Town. But to us here at TrueAnon, we'll always remember it as the site of the even worse 9/11, the Beantown bombings. In these episodes, we'll take you through the stories of two young people's experiences in the United States. Their experiences with sports, boxing, running, with chemistry, and with the United States government.

We have with us today two independent researchers who are also related and also from Beantown. We have with us independent researcher Ben Howard and independent researcher Howie. And they are much like our two— I don't know if I'll call them protagonists, but just tagonists, that's like just a neutral kind of guy— tagonists, Dzhokhar and Tamerlan Tsarnaev, who are not, by the way, interviewed in this episode. We could not get permission.

Fellas, how you doing? Welcome to the show, thank you for joining us, and thank you for suffering through that intro.

BEN 15:03
Thank you for having me again. It's always a pleasure to be here.

HOWIE 15:03
Yeah, thanks for having me. I'm excited to be here.

BRACE 15:09
Howie, welcome.

HOWIE 15:09
Yeah, thanks.

BRACE 15:09
We gotta get your guys' parents and uncles on this thing. The whole family. Yeah, so fellas, we, of course— we needed our two Boston correspondents here with us to go through— I mean, we are at the 9th anniversary of the bombings this year. Yeah, this week, just in a couple days. Yeah, exactly. It should be when this— if we time this right— I can't remember what we talked about, but when this episode comes out. If I'm wrong on that, please don't get mad at me or leave a comment or anything like that. But we've wanted to do this episode with you guys for a while. And yeah, I'm glad to finally be here. This is a big subject.

BEN 15:55
The amount of stuff— I'm just looking at our notes, it's like, you know, 30 pages of just— because there's so much—

LIZ 16:02
For part one only.

BEN 16:03
Yeah, there's so much that happens, and there's so many details that matter because there's so many inconsistencies with the various stories that have come out about this. So I'm excited for people to sit through presumably hours of us discussing this.

BRACE 16:19
Yeah, so I mean, sort of, like, back of the novel story of the Boston bombing is two brothers, both weed smokers and radical Islamists, were so fed up with America and hated the country so much that they decided to bomb the oldest marathon that's still ongoing in the world, causing mass casualties— you know, three deaths and a ton of pretty horrific injuries. They are engaged in a long manhunt with the police and are eventually— one is killed and the other is captured, and there has been sort of a— an ongoing series of court cases, and that— that is kind of the official narrative. There's probably something more to it, though, right?

LIZ 17:01
Yeah, hours more of explanation needed, because that's not exactly what happened here. I feel like before we get into the nitty gritty details and then jump into the timeline of, like, you know, the bombing and then where we're kind of going with the rest of the series— I feel like whenever Ben's on, we kind of have to start in the same place, which is the World Trade Center. And I promise I'm not actually going to link the Boston bombing to September 11th, but I just thought that would be a cute thing to

say. But I kind of want to mention something to begin our conversation, which is that for people who were— are either too young, which is most of our listeners probably, or too baby-brained, which is like the other half of our listeners probably— for those who don't remember, the World Trade Center was actually bombed prior to 9/11, back in 1993. And I think that bombing— I can't totally— I think it was like six people died, but it wounded over a hundred. It was like billions of dollars of damages. It was a huge, huge case.

And during that, the ensuing trial and the case that came out of it, this man named Emad Salem kind of came forward. And he was an Egyptian army officer who had been turned an informant for the FBI, and probably due to the fact that he was Egyptian army trained, he ended up actually taping all of his conversations— which, by the way, TrueAnon hot tip: if you ever get turned to be a criminal informant for the FBI, which, by the way, first off, don't do that, but second off, if you do, tape all of your conversations— because this guy did, and then somehow the New York Times got a hold of all of those tapes. And so I'm just going to read really quickly some of the reporting for the New York Times there, because I just want to— I think this is a good way to just kind of— something to keep in mind as we start going through this story of the Boston bombing.

So, "Law enforcement officials were told that terrorists were building a bomb that was eventually used to blow up the World Trade Center, and that they planned to thwart the plotters by

secretly substituting harmless powder for the explosives, the informer said after the blast. The informer was to have helped the plotters build the bomb and supply the fake powder, but the plan was called off by an FBI supervisor who had ideas about how the informer, Emad Salem, should be used.

"The transcripts are being closely studied by lawyers looking for signs that Mr. Salem and law enforcement officials, in their zeal to gather evidence, may have crossed the legal line into entrapment, a charge that the defense counsel has already raised. The tapes offer a rare glimpse into the sensitive relationship between the confidential informer and the law enforcement officials with whom he worked. They also reveal for the first time how federal and police agents instructed him to pump up a suspect for information and negotiate a $1 million fee from the government for his services."

So we've done episodes— we did an episode on the Gretchen Whitmer plot. We haven't, but— done an episode on Whitey Bulger, but people are probably pretty familiar with that case. Which I actually think was kind of going to trial right at the same time as the Boston bombing, weirdly enough.

BRACE 20:13
Big year for Boston.

LIZ 20:15
Yeah, big year. But Boston itself has had a very kind of, let's say, close-knit relationship with the FBI, the mob, and whatever kind of blurry line— I don't know— counts as some kind of border in between the two of

those. They kind of blur into one another in Boston in a lot of instances. But I just wanted to kind of, you know, use that as a frame that— you know, the history of the FBI and criminal informants kind of being involved and, more often than not— I don't know, yeah, like this New York Times piece says— crossing the line over into entrapment. I mean, history is dotted with cases like this. Probably more than people want to admit to themselves.

HOWIE 21:01

I was going to say that there's some interesting— you know, ties with the Boston FBI and Lady al-Qaeda as well. And I believe— I can't remember the other— gosh, I'm blanking on his name, but there was— yeah. So, I mean, you know, on top of the Whitey Bulger thing, obviously, where, you know, Whitey was, you know, on the payroll as an informant and murdering his— his adversaries, basically. So.

BRACE 21:27

Yeah. That was a big scandal, is that, like, basically the Boston FBI was overseeing this guy murdering his political— or not his political, rather his criminal enemies, and kind of just, like, letting him have this reign of terror because he gave them some information he liked and probably, you know, he did some work for them. Well, it's not just the Boston FBI that uses these methods either. I mean, the FBI writ large has made extensive use of CIs, confidential informants, basically really since the 1950s in a major way. I mean, they always have. That's always been sort of a feature of,

especially, like, secret or political police. But the use of informants and snitches and essentially, like, criminals working for the United States government has increased exponentially every single year, basically since the early '60s.

You know, in the aftermath of 9/11, it became a huge tactic, especially for law enforcement in the Northeast. I mean, NYPD is famous for this kind of stuff. But yeah, I mean, as we can see with the Whitmer stuff, this is really ongoing and continues to be a very valuable tool in the old FBI tool kit, tool chest, whatever they keep their tools. I guess probably buried in someone's, like, work shed along with, like, a bunch of, like, nuts and bolts and gunpowder and stuff like that.

LIZ 22:48

Okay, so the Tsarnaev brothers. Let's talk about them before we get into kind of what happened on that fateful Wednesday, I believe, morning. Brace, do you want to give us a little high-level rundown of these two guys?

BRACE 23:08

All right. So Dzhokhar and Tamerlan, the two Tsarnaev brothers, two out of four siblings, are the sons of Anzor and Zubeidat. Am I pronouncing that right? Do you guys know how to pronounce this? I have no idea how to pronounce his mother's name. We're going with Zubeidat. Anzor is the father, he is a Chechen, and Zubeidat is an Avar. They are from, originally— I believe they met, actually, in Siberia, where Zubeidat, I think she had moved to stay with her brother. Anzor was doing his mandatory military service. They had a kid— I believe the

day after they were married, he was born— it's Tamerlan. And then they moved to Kyrgyzstan, where they had three more children: Bella, Ailina, and finally, little Dzhokhar— Dzhokhar. They moved to Chechnya in 1993.

And this is where the story gets a little funky, because Anzor's story changes kind of depending on who he's talking to. His official story is that— I mean, when they moved there in '93, the first Chechen war breaks out in 1994. First Chechen war was hugely devastating, major conflict between the Russian government and rebels in Chechnya. And Anzor says— he says that he was kidnapped and taken to a camp for Muslims by the Russian government. That's where his PTSD comes from. I don't know if there's actually any proof of that. I know he said that to get asylum in the U.S., but he said a lot of things. He said he was tortured by the FSB, but they move out of Chechnya shortly after that, which is rather understandable, and I believe move back to Kyrgyzstan.

So in 2002, the parents come to America on a 90-day visa with little Dzhokhar in tow. I think he's about three years old, and apply for asylum based on Anzor's real or maybe not real persecution at the hands of the Russian government. They are granted asylum. And for the next five years, they kind of wait until their other children are able to get over. The two daughters and Tamerlan are living with Anzor's brother, a man named Ruslan, who is working for— well, he's married to the daughter— he's working for a lot of different people, which we'll get to later. But he's married to the

daughter of Graham Fuller, who is a CIA operative, RAND employee, and Jamestown Foundation contributor. And eventually the other kids come over around 2004.

Tamerlan's 18 when he comes over here. The family has had some trouble integrating into Boston's small Chechen community. I read that there's only about 12 families there. So it seems like a pretty small, tight-knit community. By 2006, the family had permanent residency, although nobody was working, at least over the table, and the family never had much money. I think Anzor was working on cars as a mechanic under the table at some places.

Family is kind of— well, they fit right in in Boston. They're trashy and constantly getting arrested for domestic violence. If you are a wife in this family, you are getting beaten, except for the Zubeidat. And if you are a husband, you are beating your wife. They are— I got to say, they fit right in with what I imagine a townie is. They're smoking weed, they're getting wasted. They're having kids hella early. They got crazy cars. Exactly. Yeah, they got crazy cars. Their shit's falling apart. And I got to say, for all of Tamerlan being like, oh, I don't fit in here in America, he sounds like 90% of the people I've known throughout my life. I think he takes to it—

LIZ 26:46
Pretty well, actually.

26:48

BRACE

Yeah. Tamerlan actually gets arrested for domestic violence against his live-in girlfriend in 2009, which would come up later and which we'll get to when we talk about his citizenship. And so the story goes, as time goes on, Zubeidat, who is not very religious during most of her relationship with Anzor and during the beginning of her time here in America, she begins to embrace, let's say, more traditional forms of Islam, begins dressing in hijab. And sort of the general story that is put out is that she influenced Tamerlan, encouraged him, and got him to become more religious and conservative. Reality of that is a little different.

Dzhokhar is selling weed. He is smoking weed. He is, I think, really the epitome of a 2000s weed guy. He goes to college, doesn't even really go to class or anything, just smokes weed in a dorm. I haven't seen pictures of his dorm room, but one imagines that there is a Donnie Darko poster up there, maybe Fight Club, maybe The Simpsons. Oh, he's tweeting? Oh, we'll get to that later, baby. Tweeting Eminem lyrics.

27:57

LIZ

Yes, exactly. Oh man, he's losing himself, we'll say. Yes.

28:01

BRACE

I think he actually— I think he actually tweets— no, he tweets a couple lines from Slim Shady. The song "Slim Shady." Tamerlan, meanwhile, becomes a boxer, training at the Wai Kru MMA gym. And wins a couple of pretty big trophies— I guess Golden

Gloves. And he gets married to an American woman who is, I gotta say, I'll have to admit it, pretty good looking, named Katherine Russell, who's the daughter of a Yale-educated doctor. She converts to be with him, which you gotta, I mean, respect, Tamerlan, that's pretty good. He marries her, although curiously enough, not at the mosque that he usually attended, and they have a child together named Zahira, although the sort of word is, is that Tamerlan is just still fucking other women. He's going all over the place. He's spreading his seed.

Dzhokhar goes to the University of Massachusetts at Dartmouth. Is that— now, fellas, is that the—

LIZ 28:56

Dartmouth? No.

BEN 28:57

No. You see, in New England, there's about five or six names for places, and they just get reused as street names and location names repeatedly. So you just have to make sure you are always picking the correct state, because there are like 15 different Dartmouths across New England. This one is called the South Shore Dartmouth.

BRACE 29:19

That's a great scam. I mean, I'm dimly aware that some colleges have, like, ancillary colleges, like second colleges you can go to that are, like, state schools attached to the regular, like, the fancy Ivy League ones. In my— well, but you could say that factually he is going to a Dartmouth. Right?

BEN 29:41
Yeah. Howie, you know more about this than I do. Didn't he get into some pretty good colleges, better schools than UMass Dartmouth?

HOWIE 29:47
Yeah, he got into some better schools. It was definitely the least, you know, academically challenging, definitely the least prestigious school that he got into. He supposedly said that he chose it because he didn't want to have to take out student loans.

BRACE 30:03
Yeah, I mean, the family was pretty poor, right?

HOWIE 30:05
Yeah, they lived in— the apartment they lived in was— I believe they took public assistance vouchers. And yeah, I mean, they were on federal assistance for a long time, and they were— they had all kinds of scams to, you know, have second jobs where they're getting paid under the table so that they could continue to, you know, collect public assistance.

BRACE 30:25
Yeah, and Tamerlan, as far as I know, on his death certificate, I guess they listed occupation "never worked," which many of our NEET listeners right now are reconsidering their planned suicide attempts because they don't want that to be on their death certificates. But yeah, I mean, the family was basically— it's kind of funny to think about it, but, like, Dzhokhar was actually kind of doing better than most everybody else. Like, granted, he had Fs. I mean, he did

about as bad as I did in my brief attempt to go to community college, but he had a GPA of, like, negative 10. I mean, the man was basically just smoking weed and selling weed. He didn't seem like he was really going to class.

HOWIE 31:07
Yeah. But— but yeah, like you say, I mean, as far as I know, he was— he graduated high school, you know, with honors. So, so yeah, I mean, he was doing okay until that point.

BRACE 31:20
And Tamerlan was— well, Dzhokhar sort of fit in more. I mean, this is, again, the sort of general top line story that people know. Dzhokhar actually, like, you know, he was integrating into society. And by that, I mean, he was smoking weed. And again, presumably playing Grand Theft Auto: San Andreas and watching Donnie Darko on repeat. But Tamerlan was, you know, he was really into boxing and martial arts, but, like, he— he— he had sort of this resentment against America, and he feel like— he felt like he didn't fit in, right?

HOWIE 31:50
Yeah, and he, you know, famously— folks from the Wai Kru gym, you know, quoted him as— as calling one of his friends there his only American friend. So—

BRACE 32:01
Yeah, yeah. He was also— it should be known— I mean, obviously Dzhokhar famous for his Twitter account, but, you know, this comes up later and it's actually germane to the story, is that

Tamerlan himself was a poster on the Sherdog MMA forums. I have tried to find his old posts, and I'm actually banned from those forums for just— it's a long story— but I could not find those posts. But it is confirmed that he was a poster there, and in fact corresponded with some people that come up pretty prominently later in the story.

And so that's kind of where we leave it. I mean, Tamerlan's getting more into radical forms of Islam, sort of connecting with his relatives back in Central Asia and, I guess, Southwestern Russia, and that leads us to the Boston bombing. That's kind of like the Reuters, like, three paragraph story of it. Now my question to you guys is this: what is the Boston Marathon?

HOWIE 33:04

Yeah, it's a marathon and it's a holiday. I think it's a state holiday, right, Ben?

BEN 33:11

Yeah, some people get it off. I've never gotten Patriots' Day off. I don't know what the hell that is. But some people do get it off around here. And the marathon only really ends in Boston. It's mostly not in Boston, actually.

HOWIE 33:23

Yeah, yeah, it sort of cuts through western— sort of the western surrounding area of Boston, and then the finish line is downtown, so it ends up cutting through commutes for a lot of people. So a lot of people get the day off.

BEN 33:36
Yeah, that's really the main reason that people get the day off, is just it's extremely hard to get into work on Marathon Monday. Like, if you work anywhere downtown, like, basically the main— you know, like, Boylston through the Back Bay is shut off, and, like, a lot of the main commuting routes into the city are basically shut down because of it. So yeah, a lot of people end up getting the day off. And it's got a— you know, Patriots' Day, you know, Massachusetts, they like to think of themselves as being, you know, the most important state. So it's a— it's a— it's fitting.

BRACE 34:05
And it's— I know it's a— it's a pretty big event too. Like, I mean, listen, you guys know me, I'm a marathon guy. I'm always running this, this place and that, but, you know, the Boston Marathon is, like, the big marathon. I mean, it's one of the only marathons I can really name, I guess.

BEN 34:20
It's definitely— I mean, I feel like it's pretty prestigious to win. I mean, I'm not a big marathon person, but, I mean, maybe it's just because I have lived in New England for a long time that I think of it that way. But definitely, I feel like even interna— I mean, tons of runners come from all over the world to come and race.

LIZ 34:36
I think it's, like, A-tier marathon. It's, like, up there with LA and New York. It's, like, the big kind of— you know, you travel in for it, and, you know, it's hard to get into. You know,

it's like one of those— like, you have to get— you know, you have to kind of, like, earn your stripes in order to get in, or it's a lottery that you have to— you know, you have to win to get in. But yeah, it's a big deal. It's, you know, pretty big deal, I think.

BEN 34:58

I think if you were going— basically, I mean, the reason that I think it's important is that if you were going to pick a day in Boston to do something— you know, to blow something up— I mean, this would be, you know, this and, like, Red Sox opening day, you know what I mean? Those would be, like, the two— the two days you would want to hit.

LIZ 35:13

What about St. Patrick's Day?

BEN 35:15

That's a good point. You're also going to hit bar crawlers. There's, like, too many locations.

BRACE 35:19

Yeah, yeah, yeah.

BEN 35:21

Yeah.

BRACE 35:21

Yeah. What about a showing of that movie that's, like, the two, like, Irish Catholic guys that, like, go shoot people? Boondock Saints?

BEN 35:28

I was going to say which one, and actually—

35:31

BRACE

You know, now that Dzhokhar— with Dzhokhar's weed smoking lifestyle, he's probably seen that movie 10,000 times too. And I know the marathon also coincides with a Red Sox game getting out, always, of course, culminating in a big win for that team. And so, you know, towards sort of when a lot of the runners are coming in, this game is coming out, it's getting out, and so there's a ton more people sort of spilling out onto the streets, drunk most likely, if I know my stereotypes correctly, and carousing. Drunk on—

36:05

LIZ

Patriotism.

36:06

BRACE

Exactly. And also likely some lager, Liz. And just flooding the streets with people. So this is like a giant day packed with people. Yeah, I mean, it's kind of a big party. Yeah, yeah, yeah. And I think it's time that we really get to the meat of it, and that is the bombing itself.

36:42

LIZ

So most of what we know about what happened during the actual bombing comes from either eyewitness reports, photographs taken from the moment just after the bomb hit, and security cameras from along Boylston, the street where the marathon ends and the two bombs are set off. So it's April 15th, 2013, Marathon Monday. We're in Beantown, greatest city in the world. Two bombs are detonated near the finish line of the annual Boston Marathon, just 14 seconds apart, at 2:49 and 43 seconds, and 2:49 and 57

seconds p.m. in the afternoon.

So eventually, after a period of days, the FBI names Tamerlan Tsarnaev and Dzhokhar Tsarnaev as the culprits behind the bombing. What we know about how they planted those bombs on that day is basically thanks to FBI testimony. So this is essentially the government's narrative of events leading up to the bombing, supported by some, though incomplete, surveillance video footage.

HOWIE 37:50

There's a lot of cameras around the Back Bay area, which is where the marathon finish line is and where the bombs were set off. So from local businesses and that sort of thing. And so we know that they were walking towards Boylston Street around 2:37 p.m., which is about 12 minutes before— 13 minutes before the bombs actually went off. And so we have some— I think, you know, we don't have any footage of them parking the car or in the car on the way there. But that's kind of the first time that we really see them, is around that 13 minutes before the bombs are set off.

LIZ 38:31

Yeah, people might be familiar with some of the images from this video. They would get passed around, eventually identifying the two suspects as Tamerlan and Dzhokhar.

HOWIE 38:40

Yeah, if you've seen the photo of the one brother wearing the white hat and the other wearing the black hat, that's from them walking down Boylston Street, which is the street that the marathon finishes on, and it was the

street that the— the bombs were set off on. So they kind of enter Boylston about two, like three, four blocks from where they would eventually place the bombs, and they're walking east on Boylston kind of together, loosely. And then at one point Dzhokhar stops about a block and a half from the finish line, or maybe a block from the finish line, and Tamerlan keeps walking on. And we don't really have good footage of Tamerlan, but we have some decent footage of Dzhokhar kind of stopping there and setting his backpack down and then looking at his phone a lot.

BRACE 39:33

Yeah, I feel like I've seen that footage of Dzhokhar sort of, like— I don't know what the word is, but, like, slung— slinging off his backpack, like, kind of, like, shouldering it off, you know. He's standing in another crowd, wearing— I believe he was the one wearing the white hat, right?

HOWIE 39:33

Yeah.

BRACE 39:33

A lot of heavy— you know, they will— they will— we will know them by their symbols. But yeah, he sort of puts his— puts his backpack down on the ground, and he stands there for a second, right?

HOWIE 40:01

Yeah, he does. He stands there for a bit, about four minutes, according to one of the FBI agents' testimony. And this FBI guy says, you know, emphasizes that he's looking at his

phone a lot. It seems like he's taking a picture with it, like holding it at a waist level. And the FBI agent describes him as manipulating his phone. I don't know what that means, but—

BRACE 40:26
That just means using it. That's what cops always say— that. It just means using something, but it makes it sound— I mean, I guess it was sinister, but it makes it sound— they always say that.

LIZ 40:34
And for our Zoomer listeners, by the way, this is not an iPhone or BlackBerry. This is a little flip phone. So perhaps was doing a little T9 texting, as we all remember, which was always kind of a pain in the ass and did take some real manipulation skills. Perhaps that's what he's referring to.

HOWIE 40:51
Yeah, certainly not as efficient for texting. So yeah, so he's kind of playing around on his phone, and then there's supposedly video that shows him appearing to talk on the phone, which is corroborated by some of the cell phone logs that they introduced in the testimony. And so there's a couple phone calls between the two brothers. So I guess Dzhokhar had set up a phone the day before. So I think it was like a burner phone. And so it's a phone— so Tamerlan calls Dzhokhar around 2:48 p.m., which is a little less than two minutes before the bombs go off. And then, so that— we can kind of presume that that was probably Tamerlan calling Dzhokhar to

let him know— to let Dzhokhar know that Tamerlan was in position, because they had split up at that point.

And then there is another call, kind of, you know, maybe 40— 30, 40 seconds before the bomb— the first bomb is set off, and that one was Dzhokhar calling Tamerlan, and that call lasted about 19 seconds. Like I said, so that was— there's a second phone call that happens about 40 seconds— 30, 40 seconds before the first bomb detonates. And the first bomb detonates closer to Tamerlan, and then there's a gap of about 15 seconds, and then the second bomb detonates closer to Dzhokhar. And there's video— so again, we don't have video of Tamerlan. I haven't seen any of this video. I'm just looking at, you know, the testimony that the FBI agent Anthony Imel— and he was the— he was a forensics expert who was kind of in charge of all the video and photo forensics. So, you know, I mean, make what you will of that. But we supposedly have this video and we have the phone logs that corroborate it.

Right before— so after the phone call from Dzhokhar to Tamerlan, the second phone call, there's video of Dzhokhar kind of walking away from the bomb and then it explodes. And again, there's— one of the things they point out is when the first bomb goes off, everybody who's there to watch the marathon is kind of looking east towards the direction that the first bomb blew up. Yeah. And, you know, one of the FBI agents, David Genk, he says that Dzhokhar, your first name was Bomber 2, appears calm and he's focused looking the other direction of everyone else, and then sort of calmly

but rapidly begins moving west, so in the opposite direction, and then about 10 seconds later, Bomber 2 detonates.

BRACE 43:56

And these are pretty big detonations, right? I mean, I guess we can get to the actual damage that they caused in a second, but I mean, they are, as far as we know, pressure cookers filled with essentially, like, debris, you know, BBs and stuff like that, and filled in with the guts of fireworks, you might call it— I guess, like, sort of the powder, the explosive powder that comes in bigger fireworks. And the— you can actually— I mean, this is pretty famous footage at the Boston Marathon— is sort of— is it— is itself a sort of famous event for how much footage came out of the aftermath, mostly of these, but there is footage from one of the security cameras of basically the moment when— when I believe it's Dzhokhar's bomb actually goes off.

And— and, you know, it is a— essentially, like, resembles, I guess, what most people would think of as, like, an IED. You know, it is not, like, a giant fertilizer bomb that causes this huge mushroom cloud explosion or anything like that. But it is a bomb with the maximum intent of causing injuries, very horrific injuries, right? Because I believe there was only three direct deaths actually caused by both of the bombs. But one of the big things about this is that a ton of people lost their legs. I mean, that is one thing that you kind of come to over and over and read about the Boston bombing, is how many fucking people literally just had their legs blown out from under them.

HOWIE 45:23
Yeah. Yeah. And yeah, I mean, like you said, they were designed for maximum harm. And yeah, there's only three deaths, but there was something like 250 to 300 people who were injured. And like you say, a lot of people who lost, you know, legs, arms.

BRACE 45:39
Yeah. So after these guys drop off the bomb, where do they actually, like, go to? I mean, is there any— is there any idea of, like, where they kind of— like, how they make their escape? 'Cause I— I gotta say, guys, I'm putting a bomb down, I'm giving, like, three minutes for me to get out of there. I mean, there's just, like, a mass of people around there, because, like, what if you trip? Like, you know, you want— you want some— but— but they leave the timing pretty tight, it looks like.

HOWIE 46:06
Yeah, they did. They left it pretty tight. Dzhokhar, like I said, he's only— gets out of there like, you know, 10— it's— there's only a 15 second gap between the two explosions, and there's footage— there's footage of Dzhokhar, you know, being on the scene for a few seconds before he starts to leave. So he cut it pretty close. There is footage of Dzhokhar walking. So basically what happens is the bombs go off. We have footage of Dzhokhar. He walks basically to the nearest cross street and starts walking north. So they're walking west and north. And Tamerlan, we don't have footage of him until he's a couple blocks away, but from that you can presume that he did the same thing:

walked west to the nearest cross street and then walked north. And we can, you know, just assume that they were basically walking to their car, and the reason, you know, we can assume that is because they were spotted, actually, bizarrely, at a Whole Foods 20 minutes later.

BRACE 47:04
Have you guys seen the footage from that?

LIZ 47:06
Yeah.

GUEST 47:06
No, I haven't.

BRACE 47:06
It is bizarre. I mean, it is like Dzhokhar, like, like chilly, I don't know how to describe it, but he like just like strolls into a Whole Foods and like kind of like bends over in front of the milk, like stoned. Stoned, yeah. Being like, what, they make milk out of oats now? What the fuck? Like, but he's, you know, he's sort of like trying to figure out— you can clearly see him trying to remember which milk he was told to buy. I believe he ends up buying skim milk. He just buys this milk— With cash. With cash. He goes out, Tamerlan's chilling in the car. He goes out and Tamerlan's like, no dude, wrong milk. And he has to go back to exchange milks. I don't know what milk he ends up leaving with. Regular milk.

LIZ 48:01
He exchanges twice. This is what's so weird. Okay, so like, okay, this is what, 20 minutes after the second

bomb, right? So they're at a Whole Foods, fucking Whole Foods. He goes in, he buys the skim milk with the cash, he strolls out. I believe the word we're looking for is, like, with swag. Like, he's like, shit, like, there is no— he's not rushing, you know, like he's just kind of like strolling on in.

BRACE 48:27
Liz, I don't know if he's swagged out. I don't think that's fair.

LIZ 48:31
I'd say it's like early— he's got like a touch of early swag.

BRACE 48:34
Okay, I'll accept that. Yeah, he's in pre-swag form.

LIZ 48:38
Yeah. Then he comes out and he, he realizes it's the wrong milk, he goes back in, he gets the regular milk, he goes back out, then he goes back in to get a different half gallon of milk. And so there's three trips into Whole Foods 20 minutes after the second bomb goes off at the marathon.

BRACE 49:02
This, to me, completely and totally bizarre. This to me is like the most— like, no matter what explanation you have for the events of this afternoon, this defies every single thing I can think of. Like, it is totally bizarre. I mean, I cannot even imagine, like, they are, they are just so— I mean, he— it's like the most mundane— it's literally going to the store to buy milk, like the most mundane kind of task you can think of. And it's almost

like, oh yeah, all right, we got to do this, whatever, the Boston bombing thing, we really need to remember to get the milk before we go home. Or like—

LIZ 49:40

Well, yeah, because they go back not to their place but to like their childhood home, right? So they were clearly, like, bringing milk home for the family. Like, oh, before you come back, please pick up some milk on your way home. That's the kind of vibe it has.

BEN 49:53

Because it was right down the block from 410 Norfolk, where they were, where they were living at that time, which was the family home. The other thing that is just— what's crazy about this timeline is, first off, how did they find a place to park at this event? I mean, it's extremely difficult to park in this neighborhood just on like a regular, like, weekend, you know, like on a regular Saturday or on a workday. But somehow they've managed to find a parking spot on Marathon Monday. And then were able to drive. It's not a far distance, but at this— but given the traffic disruptions and how busy this day is, I mean, it's like gridlock traffic.

So that, yeah, the fact that they were able to get back to their— apparently, I mean, we don't know for sure, but what the government says is that they went back to their car and were able to leave. I mean, this is just speculation on my part, but— and we'll get into the fact that there seem to have been other people that were involved in this who are— have not

been indicted at any point. But I have wondered, like, did somebody drive them and drop them off, yeah, and pick them up after the fact? That seems like a possibility, just because the speed with which they were able to get from— again, it's not a far distance, but given the traffic that, you know, that was around at that point, they could have parked their car there beforehand and gotten a ride down there and then taking their car to leave.

BRACE 51:06

You know, it's like it's, it is— I mean, again, I'm, I've been to, I've been to Beantown precisely once. And frankly, I've never parked there in my life. But if it's anything like a downtown of any other city in America, and if it's anything like an event day in any other city in America, parking is about the biggest nightmare that you can imagine, besides, of course, being in a horrible bomb blast. But yeah, it is pretty— I mean, it's pretty insane, like, especially in the immediate aftermath of something like this, where there are going to be a lot of emergency vehicles and sort of people fleeing. I mean, they are really able to just, like— it's almost like this security camera footage that captures them from just like a regular day. Like it does, it seems totally disconnected from the bombings.

HOWIE 51:55

Yeah. And Tamerlan was, was on the phone with his buddy, telling him that they were at the store buying milk too.

52:03

BRACE

Yeah, I know. That's the wild thing about— I mean, we can get that into that in a little bit when we talked about the manhunt. But the wild thing too is that, like, they just seem to have just, like— because I gotta say, if I was, if I did something like this, I would probably be like, oh, I'm, like, sick, I can't hang out. But they were like, oh, you know, like, let's get dinner, and like, you know, talk to their friends, like making plans for the next couple of days in, like, a really sort of blasé manner that, like— I mean, I believe their friends are like, we had literally no idea. Because, because it is like they acted like they had absolutely nothing to do with this.

But tell us a little bit maybe about the official response that comes down. Because I know that there was a— I mean, this was a huge— I mean, this is a giant event, and sort of the authorities really sprang into action right away, right?

52:49

HOWIE

Yeah, they did. And, you know, the FBI took over the scene pretty early on, and a few— you know, according to the local cops, they kind of butchered that. You know, I've heard some details that it was a windy day and they were using— they were, they were using spray paint when they should have used something else to mark details on the scene. And they left bodies, they left the dead bodies on the scene for hours—

BRACE 53:17
Yeah.

HOWIE 53:18
To the point that the local police were, you know, sort of standing guard of those bodies.

BRACE 53:25
Yeah, I mean, they shut down cell service too, right?

HOWIE 53:29
They did, yeah. And that's what's kind of interesting about the phone calls, using the phones. There's a lot of people who say that they shut down cell service. The cell providers claim that they didn't. But, you know, there's some people who speculate that— so let me back up a little bit. The supposed detonation mechanism— these are remote detonation bombs. The supposed detonation mechanism was sort of like a remote control car remote, basically. They only recovered one remote, and there's no footage of Dzhokhar having used that remote. So I suppose— I guess we're supposed to believe that Tamerlan used that remote. But basically, you know, there's some questions about, if you only have one remote, you probably only have one frequency, and there's two bombs, and they were set off at different times. So how is that supposed to work?

Long story short, there's a lot of people who theorize that they might've been using cell phones to detonate those bombs. And that was probably why the cell phone service was shut down or blocked or jammed or something. And that kind of gets into the JFK Library

fire, which is very, very bizarre timing as well.

BRACE 54:46

Yeah. So tell us about what happened with that too, because I think that is something that I was not familiar with before we started research on this episode. I thought he was dead. I didn't even know he had a library now. I mean, this is a huge revelation for me.

HOWIE 54:59

Yeah, so JFK, you know, Massachusetts hero, he— so there's a library, JFK Library, which is kind of in— it's kind of south and east of downtown Boston, of Back Bay. And basically about five minutes after the bombs went off, there's this fire that breaks out at this JFK Library. It's about three, three, four miles from the explosions on Boylston Street. And, you know, there's photos of this black billowing smoke coming out of this library, and there's a lot of back and forth between the police, you know, who initially described the explosion, and they described the device, and they said that, you know, they might have thought that it was related to the Boston— to the marathon bombings. And then later that day, the same day, Monday, that afternoon, the— you know, the BPD commissioner who had originally said that there was a third incident sort of walked back his statement and just said that it was, it was not an explosion. It was just a fire.

But, you know, a lot of people describe— there was a grad student there, and, you know, he describes basically a very quick escalation of

this fire. And, you know, if they did in fact use cell phones to, you know, set off the marathon bombs, I think it's probably, you know, possible that they could have also used cell phones to set off some kind of device in the library. And again, just want to point out, the library is south and east of where the bombings happened, and their escape route from the bombings was north and west, to some car that took them, you know, north to Cambridge. And so it seems possible that this fire was some kind of distraction to draw law enforcement attention away from, you know, their escape route.

LIZ 57:06
But the cops come out later and say, we don't believe that this was related, right? Like, the kind of response and the story around the fire is very confusing.

HOWIE 57:15
Yeah, they did. And I believe the Boston Police Commissioner, Ed Davis, kind of walked back his statement where, you know, he originally said that he thought it was related, and he sort of walked it back, that it was just a fire and it's not related, nothing to see here.

BRACE 57:34
Which seems insane to me. Yeah, I mean, it's a hell of a timing. I mean, so, you know, we mentioned these bombs and the remote controls on them, and so I think, I think it's worth describing, you know, what these bombs were, right? Like, you mentioned pressure cookers. I don't really— I'll be real with you guys, not I— my, my cooking stuff, I'll go— I do the pan,

I'll do the pot, I'll do a rice cooker, toaster. To me, pressure cooker, level above that. Frankly, I don't really know what— my main thing in my head, I'm not even joking here, they're used to make bombs. Like, they should just, just be illegal. What do you cook in them?

BEN 57:34

Beans.

BRACE 57:34

Oh my God. Come on. Christ. Come on, man.

BEN 58:22

Yeah. Look, if you've got dry beans and you need to get your edible Boston baked beans, that's the fastest way to do it, is in a pressure cooker.

BRACE 58:29

That's crazy you say that, because there's literally no reason, if you live in the first world, to buy dry beans. You could just buy— they come wet. You can get them wet, for enough to eat for a very reasonable price.

But these were specific pressure cookers that were available in only one department store in the USA. Well, one chain of department stores. And that would be Macy's, which is sort of, for those who don't know, like, it's like Nordstrom's for women. I jest there. I don't really know the difference between either of them, but it is a department store à la Nordstrom's. And they are only available there. They're called Fagor? Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. That is a great name.

59:15

BEN

I think they're European too, aren't they? Made by some European company.

59:16

BRACE

With a name like that, they are definitely European, Ben. But you can only purchase them there. And like you said, they were filled with basically gunpowder and BBs and stuff like that. And, you know, I'm sure many people saw the footage of the aftermath of the bombing, with people whose legs are just, like, scattered all over the ground. Reading people's sort of first-person reminiscences of being hit in these blasts are, you know, it's, it's awful to read. You know, eight-year-old boy was killed, I know a woman was killed, and I believe a man was killed as well. And I mean, it just was this sort of, like, giant out-of-nowhere explosion for these people. And really, really, it seems like a lot of the blast kind of came at below the knee level for most people. And it just— I mean, totally devastating. You know, like there was, I think, like I said, 17 immediate, like, amputations— not like by a doctor, by, like, the bomb blowing people's limbs off. And then I think a slew of amputations after the fact of mangled limbs.

A lot of people basically— I mean, this ruined their lives. You know, it is, it is a— there were, there were three, but in, in, in— you know, in war, there's sort of the doctrine, or the idea, rather, of it's better to shoot somebody and injure them than to shoot someone and kill them, because if you injure somebody, it takes several other people out of the fight,

because they have to load them onto a stretcher, and it takes resources to heal them back, and blah, blah, blah. And it sort of seems like the same idea here. It didn't kill a lot of these people, but it severely affected and basically ruined the rest of their lives.

HOWIE 1:01:13
You know, these bombs used at the marathon were remote detonate. And, you know, there was a lot that was made of this supposed bomb-making recipe that was found in the Norfolk Street apartment, the family apartment, from Inspire magazine, which I believe is an al-Qaeda magazine. Is that right?

BRACE 1:01:31
Yeah, yeah, yeah. Ben did a couple, like, op-eds for them.

BEN 1:01:34
Yeah, that's right. I got my start there. Yeah.

BRACE 1:01:37
Yeah, yeah.

BEN 1:01:38
Funny enough, Inspire was actually run by al-Qaeda— supposedly run by al-Qaeda Arabian Peninsula. Yeah. And Anwar al-Awlaki had some of it— did actually get, you know, had a writing career there.

BRACE 1:01:51
Yes, yeah, yeah.

1:01:52

BEN

And of course, we discussed the fact that Anwar al-Awlaki was very likely an FBI informant of some kind. So it's just sort of a nice little touch here that they were allegedly informed.

1:02:02

BRACE

Yeah, one of those cosmic coincidences. It's like the Paris Review or something.

1:02:06

HOWIE

Yeah, that's right. And maybe in a little nod to that, you know, Tamerlan and— I mean, some people say Dzhokhar, I don't know, but at least Tamerlan was watching Anwar Awlaki videos.

1:02:18

BRACE

Yeah, but the recipe in the Inspire sort of bomb— it's like, isn't the article called, like, "How to Make a Bomb in Your Mother's Kitchen"? Yeah. But the recipe for that wasn't exactly the recipe that they used, though, right?

1:02:31

HOWIE

Yeah, that's right. So that recipe— my understanding is that that recipe was very crude, and this, you know, what they recovered on Boylston Street was much more advanced. And again, you know, used a remote detonation mechanism, which is, you know, pretty serious, and probably not something that, you know, they would have been able to make themselves. And, you know, on top of that, prosecutors in Dzhokhar's case would later say, actually, that there's no evidence that the two of them made those bombs.

BRACE 1:03:08

Yeah, I mean, that is— as far as we know, I mean, we do know that they have basically this whole— everyone's Google searches, everyone's internet history. I mean, that comes out with, you know, Tamerlan's wife and everybody. And if they had, like, how to make bomb, or like Anarchist Cookbook PDF, like, that— we do not— that, that did not appear in court. We do not have that. As far as anybody knows, nobody knows who actually made these bombs. Like, that has never been— never been put out there. That has never been proven. And in fact, I believe that's pretty much the accepted explanations, like, well, we don't actually know for sure who made these bombs. Which seems so crazy, like the—

LIZ 1:03:49

It's also a detail that's though previously not highlighted ever. Like, you're right to point out that the prosecution even said that, the FBI has said that, but it's certainly not in the, like, really, like, avalanche of coverage that was— you know, the Boston Globe, it was like this was— I mean, understandably, but also pretty insanely— the only story they covered for like 15 months. You know, that wasn't really something that was like, wait a second, where's the other person? You know, there was a couple of intrepid reporters that I'm, I'm sure we're going to talk about who were really trying to follow that and say, like, wait a second, you know, you keep referring to the fact that, you know, they couldn't have made these bombs, or this doesn't line up, like, there has to be a third person,

at bare minimum, third person, if not more, involved. Why aren't we chasing that? And it just was never— that was not something that was making the cover of the papers.

HOWIE 1:04:41

Yeah, and I mean, you know, that's probably your first question, right? I mean, who made the bombs? Who gave them the bombs? And then, you know, did they have any help in getting to and from the actual event? And again, suspiciously, I find it hard to believe. I mean, if you've ever been to Back Bay, it's just lined with businesses, and, you know, the richest homes you've seen, probably the most, you know, Ring doorbells you've ever seen in your life. It's crazy to me that there's no footage of Tamerlan and— I mean, the two of them from the car on the way to Boylston Street.

BEN 1:05:22

Yeah, yeah. Because they would have, they would have walked down an extremely busy commercial stretch for quite a while. Like you said, they would have passed by all kinds of homes and businesses, wherever they were parked, like where they were on—

LIZ 1:05:35

You mean prior to the bombing?

BEN 1:05:36

Yeah, yeah, when they arrive at the scene and somehow walk to where they allegedly— you know, I mean, I guess it's not alleged since Dzhokhar's been convicted, but according to the government, what happened is that they placed those bombs. And yeah, the only footage is from, like, the Forum

restaurant, you know, like right near where the, where the, where the, where the government's talking about.

HOWIE 1:05:54

There's a Montessori, Montessori school.

BRACE 1:06:00

Oh, God. Well, that's a— don't get me started on those things. I majored in hugging when I went to one of those. I'm just— I never went to Montessori school, I want to be clear to all the haters out there.

Yeah, it is, it is— I mean, there is— it is sort of mind-boggling how, like— I mean, some of the footage— I believe there's the footage of Dzhokhar that was taken with an iPhone across the street that somebody has, of, like, a different angle. That's supposedly how the FBI, like, finally positively identified a suspect— not, they didn't say it was him, but, you know, they had, like, pictures of who they think did it via that iPhone footage. But there is, like, a sort of shocking lack of footage besides the sort of well-known stuff of, like, the black hat, white hat sort of footage of these guys walking around together. A, an incredible lack of footage of both of them, even with the TV cameras around there, right? I mean, they're, they're right near the finish line. You know, you'd think you'd, you'd pick some of them up. And, you know, as, as from what, what I— and what I understand about this investigation is there was literally a terminal, like a cruise ship terminal, filled with various law enforcement officials whose job it was, was to go over footage and try to find something

suspicious.

And I got to say, that Forum restaurant footage of, you know, Dzhokhar allegedly, like, putting his backpack down and then sort of staying there and walking away, even if, like, you can kind of, like— it's like, I watched, like, a really kind of shitty, like, true crime style documentary on this. It's like an ABC documentary, just to see footage. And you can definitely tell that guy's up to something. You can clearly see him shrug off a backpack there. But apparently it took them a long time— although, well, relatively long time— although it does seem apparent that the FBI might've been holding some cards pretty close to their chest.

So April 15th is when the bombing happens. And, you know, you guys, I assume— I mean, you guys are Beantown born and bred, right? I mean, you— we got Damon and Ben Stiller, the other guy. Were you guys in Boston at the time?

BEN 1:08:11
I was living in New York at the time, actually.

BRACE 1:08:13
Oh, very convenient.

BEN 1:08:16
I wasn't in town, exactly.

BRACE 1:08:19
Howie, were you in Boston at the time?

HOWIE 1:08:21
No, I was not. I was, I was in New Hampshire. Yeah.

1:08:26

BRACE

Wow, it's interesting. Interesting, the two brothers were out of town when this happened. But this was a pretty fucking big event. I mean, I remember when this happened— oh yeah, and I was so high for all of 2013. It, you know, it was, it was sort of this, like— you know, there's a lot of news coverage of bombing plots that get foiled by the— I remember there was a pretty— there was a, at least in the Bay Area, sort of a locally well-known one of a guy, I think it was, going to bomb Fisherman's Wharf. And, you know, there was always these sort of, like, foiled terrorist attacks. And, and this one was covered with this sort of, like— you know, this is like the new 9/11, like the Boston— Boston has been struck in the same way that, like, you know, New York was. And it was, it was a giant deal in Boston. I mean, the whole city was locked down pretty shortly after.

1:09:18

HOWIE

Yeah, you know, when that was still— you know, the idea that you would have a shelter in place, when that was still an insane thing, right?

1:09:26

BRACE

Mm-hmm.

1:09:27

LIZ

That's true, yeah. So the big manhunt begins basically, what, the night of the 15th? I mean, they shut— like we said, they shut down cell service at some point. They kind of shut down the city even more so than it had already been set up to be kind of shut down for the marathon, right? Because so much traffic was already kind of

blocked off to kind of ready the city for the marathon.

But we mentioned the feds come in, take over the investigation. They get kind of into a classic, like, movie style, the turf war between the local cops and the feds, where everyone is sort of like, oh, who's in charge here? Well, I'm in charge. We're on the same side. We're not on the same side. This is my The Town. No, this is my The Town. Yeah, I'm the bean boy or whatever. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. But they, the, the feds, like— I mean, we mentioned that they keep everything kind of close to their chest. They're not really sharing information with the local cops, and the whole thing seems to devolve into, like, a total fucking shit show, per the words of the, like, local PD, who have, like, really come out in the years since talking about what a mess this thing was.

BRACE 1:10:37

Well, the FBI immediately, I believe actually the next day, searched an apartment in Revere Beach, which is— is that named after Paul Revere? I assume so. It might be, I'm not sure. It must be, let's say it is. Yeah, it is, yeah, it is. Classic beach guy, I always associate him with the way—

BEN 1:10:37

That's the first thing I associate him with.

LIZ 1:10:58

Well, it's—

1:10:59

BRACE

Two if by sea. Paul Revere, he loved the beach. But they immediately searched the Revere Beach apartment belonging to a Saudi national, a student, and they carry a ton of black bags out of the apartment. And by black bags, I mean they were probably fucking trash bags, but, like, evidence bags that the FBI brought with them. The student is a guy— and check this out, if you want to eventually cancel me for mispronunciation, I'm about to give you a lot of ammunition. Abdul... Actually, I got this easy. Abdulrahman Ali Alharbi. He was a... Yeah, you like that? That looked intimidating, but you know what? Really easy once you sound it out.

The student, Abdulrahman, had actually been injured in the blasts, and he was being treated in a hospital. The police kept him under guard. They go to the hospital and I think believe they do the classic lock you to the fucking side of the hospital bed thing. John Kerry immediately has a closed-door meeting with the Saudi foreign minister, likely about this. And I got to say, if we're having closed-door meetings with the Saudi foreign minister every time, like a, you know, maybe like an Air Force cadet shoots up a bunch of people, or, you know, et cetera, et cetera, that's a lot of closed-door meetings. And— but it turns out he didn't do it. Right?

HOWIE 1:12:20
Well, that's what we're told, anyway. Yeah. I mean, that's one of those things where it's like, it's this insane thing, and it was just a one-off thing, and there was nothing— no one ever talked about it again.

BRACE 1:12:34
Yeah, and I guess Michelle Obama met with him in the hospital. Yeah, she did. Which is, I gotta say, worth it if you're— I mean, she's a good-looking lady. And by the way, listeners who are listening for a little bit of tea, I have it on good information from multiple sources that both Obama daughters are all over LA doing cocaine and not tipping at a certain bar I could name, but I will not. So if you are looking for cocaine, look for Barack Obama's daughters in Los Angeles.

LIZ 1:13:09
So just ignore the big guys in the suits next to them.

BRACE 1:13:11
They don't care, they don't care. I asked about this. I was like, so they're just there?

LIZ 1:13:15
If you see that, though, it's probably the safest, because, you know, they— you know, those guys got a lot of Narcan on them.

BRACE 1:13:24
Yes, yeah, yeah, true. So don't worry about it. Getting a fentanyl test strip from a fucking Secret Service agent.

Weirdly enough, his apartment building was right next to a certain carjacking victim's, right? Yeah, that's right. Which is very— I mean, we'll get to that, I guess, a couple of days later. But at this point, there are no photos. Nobody knows officially, or at least it's not out yet, who any bombing suspects are. It's still up in the air. We don't know who did this. We are looking for any information, tip line. They have a couple of command centers set up, or I think one command center, and then this giant research center. From what I gather, like I said, it's all guys sitting around these little terminals looking at videos. And of course, there's a bunch of people collecting evidence of these bombs and backpacks and BBs and all these sorts of things.

But April 16th, which I believe is a Tuesday, that day ends with no real, at least public, forward movement on the case. On April 17th, my— I don't want to say favorite— moment happens, but one of the most, I think, culturally everlasting things from the Boston bombing comes out, which is Dzhokhar Tsarnaev, who spends the day chilling with his homies, tweets, "I'm a stress-free kind of guy." Which is— I mean, what is your guys' interpretation of that?

HOWIE 1:14:51

Yeah, I mean, they just went back to their lives, man. I mean, they, you know— Tamerlan was boxing, Dzhokhar was smoking weed with his friends in college. They were just chilling. I don't know what the hell was going on.

LIZ 1:15:05
It's hard to, like, look at this behavior with— so there's a large manhunt underway in Boston, in the city they live in. If they had just perpetrated these crimes, which we can get into later, you know, when we get into the trial and everything. But this is not behavior you would expect from guys who feel like they're being hunted by the feds.

BEN 1:15:29
Yeah. Well, and especially when you look at the fact that later— we'll get to with the carjacking and all of that— it was claimed, I mean, this is what the government says, is that they said they were going to go to New York City. Apparently, Tamerlan said that to the carjacking victim. But that was apparently not on their minds during the days in between when the bombings happen and then when that carjacking, you know, the murder of Sean Collier and all that stuff happens. So the, the— yeah, I mean, apparently they, you know— whatever, whatever their actual role in all of this was, they just went back to their lives after it was over. Despite the fact, obviously— whatever you think about what happened, they clearly had been there at the scene of a pretty horrific attack, and then just went back to their lives, like, you know, like nothing had essentially happened.

BRACE 1:16:16
I mean, that, that is sort of the astounding thing about this, right? Because, as we'll get to, the official story is later that they do indeed hijack a car and intend to set off some bombs in New York City, but they

do not seem to be very busy in preparation for this. I mean, literally, Dzhokhar is, like, hanging out in a dorm room, smoking weed, and tweeting. Like, it is about as far— these guys are not, like, constructing things, or, like, you know, or making any kind of preparation, leaving town, anything like that. They are, they are sitting tight and, and chilling, and not, like, seemingly covering their tracks, or, you know— I mean, they're, they're, they're just living their normal lives. I mean, I know Tamerlan hangs out with his wife and his kid, has people over for dinner. You know, I believe the night of the bombing itself, they have a, a friend of theirs over, a taxi cab driver, over for dinner. And they're just, like, kind of, like, chilling, like watching CNN on, like, a laptop. You know, like, just like, damn, that's crazy.

I think Dzhokhar tweets, "Ain't no love in the heart of the city. Stay safe out there." I want to say he ends it with a y'all, but memory may be failing me. He should have ended with a y'all. An early y'all. Yeah, an early y'all signing. That's a different connotation to that y'all. That is a classical you all contraction there.

And then we get to— this is two days after the bombing, April 18th, when Boston Strong is officially inaugurated.

LIZ 1:17:44
Yeah, this is very—

GUEST 1:17:45
Three days, yeah.

LIZ 1:17:48
President Obama makes a big visit to the city, which, as I'm saying this, I'm sure people listening at home are like, well, that sounds right. It was a big national tragedy. The president should come there. That makes sense. Obama loves speech. People loves when Obama speechifies. Makes sense. But you have to understand that, okay, the city is under lockdown. Something very close to martial law. I don't know what martial law is, but this would be something close to what you could describe it. I mean, the city is locked down.

Michele McPhee, who is a kind of local Boston reporter and who's written books on this case and really followed this case for years, like, she makes a big stink about this, I think because she's so close to so many in the local PD. But all of the local cops are just completely dumbfounded why the president would come to Boston during an active manhunt when the city is locked down, because basically the local police and even the federal officers are there have to completely divert so many resources to provide security for the president. The president can't just show up somewhere. There's a total detailed and planned out of routes and where Secret Service is going to be, and they have to set up different hubs. And also, at the same time, like, there's active, there's active bombers out on the run that they're trying to catch, so they're nervous also about possible terrorist attacks against the

president being there, so they have to have even more security for this than, like, what you would normally have for just a presidential visit. So the whole thing is just like— I don't really know how that got greenlit, or how someone said, okay, yeah, this is what we need right now. Because it just creates an even bigger mess on top of what is already a total disaster in terms of, like, law enforcement finding these guys.

Also, I read— I was reading back on Obama's speech. And it is like— I know everyone is like, Obama, you're such an orator, like such a classic orator.

BRACE 1:17:48

(whispering) Stop talking.

LIZ 1:17:48

Dude, this speech is really funny. Like, at one point he talks about how, like, he's like, "Every fall, Boston welcomes students from across America, and every spring you graduate them back into the world, a Boston diaspora that excels in every field of human endeavor."

BEN 1:20:12

Oh boy.

LIZ 1:20:13

"I know this because there's a piece of Boston in me." And I was like, the last thing we need to do is introduce Boston to the concept of the diaspora. Like, I just really don't think that this is what the city needs.

BRACE 1:20:24

I will say, Boston is Israel for Boston guys. It's always seemed like that to me. It's always home. Yeah, yeah, it's home. I mean, it's like they feel— they make aliyah to Boston. Like, if you're from there, that's where you belong.

BEN 1:20:41

The other thing that we haven't really gotten into yet is the fact that during this three-day period— so there's, like, this three-day interregnum between, you know, the bombings on the 15th, on April 15, 2013, and then on April 18th, like, everything else kicks off with, you know, Tamerlan allegedly murdered this police officer, etc. But during that three-day period, you know, Michele McPhee's police sources, or, like, local PD sources, have all said that they all think that the FBI knew who Dzhokhar and Tamerlan were before this. Because there's— you mentioned that terminal where all the evidence was being assembled, and one of the things that was being done there that you mentioned was they were looking over the footage, and there were in particular these two guys— Howie, I think you mentioned— they even had, supposedly— these two guys had photos of people that we don't know who was in those photos, but everybody there, all of the other police officers and FBI agents, etc., they all were like, you guys know who these people are. You know who we're looking for. Who do you have photos of?

BRACE 1:21:43
They wouldn't show anyone the photos, I think, either.

HOWIE 1:21:49
Yeah, and they had those photos, you know, that probably some of your listeners have seen, the white hat, black hat photos. They had those at some point on Monday, so on the day of the bombing, and they withheld them for three days. They didn't share them with any of the local police, you know, any of the, of the various, you know, surrounding area— because it's not just Boston, it's, you know, you know, Harvard's at Cambridge, and, and Somerville and stuff. So they sat on those for three days.

LIZ 1:22:17
And has— does anyone know why?

HOWIE 1:22:20
I'm not really sure.

LIZ 1:22:21
I mean, I don't— I haven't seen any official explanation. That was, like, more of a rhetorical why. I mean, you know, it doesn't make a lot of sense.

BRACE 1:22:27
To be clear here, it's not like the law enforcement was shy about basically casting aspersions on people. I mean, they literally went to this guy, this Saudi national's apartment, the day of the bombing. It's not like they were being cautious and being like, well, we don't want to— not to cast aspersions here, but the Boston field office of the FBI wanted to be like, well, I don't want to blame Muslims. I don't want to make

anyone feel uncomfortable towards that community. That does not sound very realistic to me. But yeah, I mean, it's very likely that they had photographs of these two guys and suspected this, or at least were looking for footage of these two guys from the get-go.

BEN 1:23:16

And then even an hour before Tamerlan is alleged to have killed this MIT police officer in Cambridge, you know, on the MIT campus, the FBI apparently was at Tamerlan and Dzhokhar's apartment in Central Square in Cambridge, near where they lived, you know, like an hour before. Yeah. And, and in fact, like, somebody even called— I think somebody called the Cambridge Police Department, like a local resident called the Cambridge Police Department, say, hey, there's a suspicious vehicle. Cambridge PD pulls up, and the guy's like, I'm a federal officer. And there were apparently several of these, yeah. And it's just, again, right in the vicinity of where Tamerlan, Dzhokhar— the family house, where there was, at 410 Norfolk. So it just— all of this points to the fact that they knew who these guys were before they— including their names— you know, before they let on. And of course, that would imply that they had a reason to suspect these two people before it was identified that they were allegedly the ones who, you know, according to the government story, dropped the bombs at the site, which is also very curious.

LIZ 1:24:24
I think it was also in McPhee's reporting, was that the federal officer that the local Boston officer approaches in that SUV that was near the family apartment— I think it was in that moment where the local cop asked for identification, and the federal officer was like, fuck off, I'm not giving you anything, I'm a fed. Yeah. And the PD— the officer's like, what? Like, no, you can't just say you're a fed, you have to, like, show me. Yeah. And the guy's like, fuck off, we're not doing it. And that's when, really— I mean, the local cops were like, there are feds all over this town that are not the ones that are just at this fucking terminal working officially.

BEN 1:25:09
And it's funny because it becomes like the— you know, McPhee, you know, she's a— she's clearly a very good reporter, but she also has got her own ideological— you know, as we all do. And some of the arguments in her book are used as follow-on from the 9/11 argument, which is we need better coordination between these agencies.

LIZ 1:25:28
I know. I thought of you a lot when I was reading it, and I was like, oh, here we go, the recommendation of the coordination of the agency. Yeah, exactly.

BEN 1:25:35
And there was this Boston Joint Terrorism Task Force that already existed and was supposed to be meant to— the ostensible purpose was to integrate all these agencies, but it

actually was just a black— it seems like the people— and because there were also non-feds assigned to the Joint Terrorism Task Force, there were, like, the state police, for instance, who also seemed to know things and be in places that it seems weird that they would have been. And again, it seems like the reality of these kinds of fusion centers is that they become a black hole of information.

LIZ 1:26:11
Like a dumping ground, basically.

BEN 1:26:12
Yeah, and they become a way to compartmentalize, because you don't want these local cops getting involved in this kind of stuff. They don't have the proper clearances, etc.

BRACE 1:26:22
Exactly, yeah. And maybe they'll talk to somebody, too.

Speaking of talking, there is a text message exchange that came out during Dzhokhar's trial between Dzhokhar and his friend Kadyrbayev, which I'm also patting myself on the back for pronouncing correctly. Kadyrbayev texts him, "you saw the news," with the little U instead of the word. Tsarnaev says, "yeah bro, I did." Kadyrbayev says, "for real?" Tsarnaev: "I saw the news. Better not text me, my friend. Lol." Kadyrbayev said, "you saw yourself there?" And then Tsarnaev says, "if you"— and that's spelled I-F-Y-U, one word— "want"— Y-U, you— "can go to my room and take what's there," smiley face, "but I, bro, salamu alaikum."

"But I, bro, salamu alaikum" is one of the— first of all, the most insane sign-off I've ever seen in a court document. You have to include the smiley face in it, too. Yeah, smiley face, but I, bro. Old school smiley face, not emoji smiley face. Oh, yeah.

LIZ 1:27:25
No, this is T9, let's remember.

BRACE 1:27:26
It's a different language, literally.

So this exchange happens because on the 18th, the Tsarnaev brothers' pictures, although not their names, are put out on the news. The law enforcement is officially designating these two guys as persons of interest in the Beantown bombing case. And this is the day that a whole lot of shit happens. So as Ben mentioned, a police officer named Sean Collier was murdered. And this is around 10:30 p.m., so pretty late at night, on MIT's campus. An MIT police officer named Sean Collier, and this is the real MIT, this isn't University of Massachusetts, MIT. He is found shot basically six times, with the final shot being right between the eyes, with a nine millimeter pistol, which later turns out to be a pistol that plays a great role in several parts of this case.

No one actually witnessed this shooting. There were people that heard it, or rather said that they heard it, sound like someone was banging on a trash can. But Sean Collier was not picking up a cell phone, he was not responding to radio calls. And when a fellow officer came by to see what was going on, they saw that the doors were

open and he was laying there. I believe he was either dead or died shortly after. I think he actually might have been barely alive, but dying irreversibly. It looks like whoever had shot him— and by the way, there is, as far as I know, I don't think that there's fully proof that the Tsarnaev brothers fired— and in fact, I do know that there is some contention, even among people who say that is proven, over whether who actually did it, of the two brothers, if they did do it. It appears that whoever did shoot him tried to get his pistol out of his duty belt.

But here's a little TrueAnon tip for you there, listeners. The way that police holsters work is not the way that regular holsters work. So you can't just grab a cop's holster out. Some of them, you need to depress the gun a little bit. Some of them, there's a little switch on the side that's kind of near the trigger, by the outside of the holster, that you need to flick in order to get it out. You can't just take a cop's gun out. Totally dangerous. I know. They should just have regular holsters that you can remove the gun very easily from. I've been lobbying for this for years. But yeah, it's always a good idea when you go to your town to figure out what kind of holsters the police use, so that if one's ever in trouble, you can help them. They have to answer, that's the law, that's a little-known law. If you ask the police, "How does your holster work?" they have to tell you. I do wish, and this is totally getting off topic here, but I really, I've mentioned this before, but I really do wish that someone would make a law

that undercover cops really do have to tell you if they're an undercover cop. That would actually be, that would go a long way.

But they could not get the gun out of the holster and had shot him. I believe he was reaching for his radio, they say, because he had a hole in his hand. I mean, you know, I— probably something like that's true, but at the same time, there was a sort of mysterious robbery at a 7-Eleven, which, you know, I think bears some kind of going into here.

HOWIE 1:30:36

Yeah, so nearby to where the shootings took place, there was a 7-Eleven, and there was a robbery at the 7-Eleven. I think the amount was like $200, and the person who reported it described, like, a white male, big build.

And interestingly, the investigation in this robbery was taken over by a federal— federal organization, with the name of that federal organization has been redacted. And interestingly, the police report, the description of the suspect was actually redacted. So I don't know how that makes any sense. I don't know.

BRACE 1:31:24

And this is a $200 robbery from a 7-Eleven, to be clear, with the name of the investigating organization and the description of the suspect both redacted?

HOWIE 1:31:33

Yes.

1:31:34

BEN

And according to the government, this is not in any way related. I mean, that's what the government says. This has nothing to do. It's completely unrelated.

1:31:41

HOWIE

Actually, interestingly, they initially thought that it might have been, held a press conference to say that it was, and then later called everyone back to say that, oh, no, actually, this was not at all related, which is interesting because, you know, usually, you know, a cop's not going to correct their mistake like that.

They did have, there was video footage from inside the 7-Eleven, and Michele McPhee, this investigative reporter we've been talking about, she showed this still from this footage to the mother of someone that she thought might have been a suspect. And that, you know, the mother said, in fact, you know, "Oh, my God, that's, that's my son." Yeah. And that, that person's name was, was— is Daniel Morley. And that's someone that we're probably going to get into a little bit later on.

1:32:33

BRACE

One of America's foremost Ron Paul Fedayeen, because he is described in the literature, and Michele McPhee describes him, as an anarchist. And while, of course, I have had my battles with the anarchists in the past, I will say this man was clearly very much a Ron Paul-style libertarian.

So this robbery is happening at the same time, and then there is a carjacking. And this is where things start to sort of— things are in motion, but the motion picks up and, and gravity kind of takes hold. Now, to sort of set the scene here, the picture of our two— our two brothers are— is out there, right? But they have not been identified. They have not— I mean, you know, as far as they know, maybe the police— the police know who they are, but the police are not saying who they are. They're asking for information on who these two guys are, which means, you can understand, their car hasn't been made yet, right? Yeah.

But they go and jack a car, very poorly, by the way. I mean, if you're just, if you're going— any way you look at this, this is a badly done crime. But they go, they jack a man's, what is it, a BMW? It might be my brain.

HOWIE 1:33:48
Yeah, I think it's a Mercedes SUV. Yeah.

BRACE 1:33:52
Yeah. And so tell— tell me, tell me what went down there.

HOWIE 1:33:56
Yeah, so, so again, just to recap, so this is April 18th, Wednesday, three days after the bombing. I believe the photos of the two brothers had been put out that afternoon or maybe that evening. 10:30 p.m. is when Sean Collier was shot, and then about a half an hour later, around 11:07 p.m., this, this man named Dun Meng, who worked in Cambridge, he was carjacked

in, in the Allston neighborhood of Boston.

And so he— what he says is that he— so he's a transportation engineer, and so he's very concerned with safety. Says he got a text from his friend and he wanted to respond, so he pulled over.

LIZ 1:34:43
Which is a very responsible thing to do, by the way. That classic move that everyone's always doing, which is pulling over to text.

HOWIE 1:34:51
In this case, I do believe him. He is a transportation engineer. He kind of seems like a nerd, I'll be honest with you.

BRACE 1:34:58
It's probably like safety engineer's code. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. And by the way, Dun Meng, his name is Dun Meng, and it is actually a nickname because he was apparently— kept telling the brothers, like, "Oh, I'm done, I'm with this, man." Oh, that's bad. I'm kidding. No, it's his real name.

BEN 1:35:15
He actually, he did, though. He did go by Danny for a long time, and it didn't come out. His real name didn't come out until the trial.

BRACE 1:35:22
Yeah. Well, that's not very uncommon. I mean, I know a lot of, you know, Chinese-born people I know that have moved over here have sort of used, like, Americanized names and stuff like that.

BEN 1:35:33

Yeah. Yeah. It's just interesting that he, you know, the reason he claims— he was concerned for his safety. I think he said also that he didn't want to be seen as a hero. There were a few reasons he gave why he was anonymous, but I can understand that he didn't want to be the center of a media spectacle.

BRACE 1:35:47

Yeah, yeah, yeah. I don't, I honestly, I'm like, this guy, just really wrong place, wrong time. Yeah, absolutely.

HOWIE 1:35:55

Yeah, so he says he was pulled over, or sorry, he says he pulled over, and then he says that he saw a car pull up behind him. And at this point, someone got out of the car and starts knocking on the window incessantly, and he says that he thought this person was gonna ask for directions, so he rolls the window down enough for this person to stick their hand inside and open the door and point a gun at his head, and asking— and ask for money, interestingly. And we later find out that this, this person was Tamerlan Tsarnaev. He actually told Dun Meng that, you know, he said something to the effect of, you know, "Did you see the, the marathon bombs? Like, I'm the guy who did it, and I just shot a cop."

BRACE 1:36:36

Stupid move.

LIZ 1:36:38
Okay. So I do want to say, like, why would, why would someone say that?

HOWIE 1:36:44
Yeah, it's, it's bizarre.

BRACE 1:36:46
Well, Liz, I mean, imagine you're like— have a secret, but you can't tell anybody, and you meet a stranger and you're like, yeah, I can— I'm trying to think of a secret I have. Like, yeah, I killed a dog a couple of years ago, 'cause I got mad.

LIZ 1:37:01
The only— like, I mean, I'm— I am trying to, like, not be too, like, you know, too debunkery or whatever, but— or to, like, you know, tin— tinfoil hat. And, you know, when we get into Tamerlan's behavior and the shootout and everything, you kind of are like, well, maybe this dude is just, like, fucking hopped up on some crazy shit and was, like, in beast mode, because then I can understand, he's like beast mode and is bragging and saying, like, who he is. Yeah. But if you're, like, carjacking and on the run from the feds who have just released your photo, like, you are fucking trying to beat the clock here to get, as he'll say apparently, to get out of Boston to go to New York to set off more bombs. Like, the last thing you want to do is kind of confess to who you are to the guy who's sitting next to you, right?

HOWIE 1:37:49
Yeah, it's, it's bizarre. I mean, the only explanation I can think of is he was just trying to intimidate him, and he probably was gonna kill him later anyways, just so that he wouldn't leave any witnesses.

BRACE 1:38:02
Yeah. I mean, they, they— Dun Meng says that, like, later they were like, "Oh, we're not going to kill you." But it's like, dog— a little TrueAnon tip here. Anyone gets into your car with a gun, they're going to kill you. There's no— like, they're not going to— what do you think? They're just going to let you go on the side of the highway? They're going to shoot you. And most of the time when people tell you they're not going to kill you, they're just making sure that you don't freak out so they can kill you easier later.

HOWIE 1:38:23
Yeah. Which is important because for a little while, Dun Meng was actually driving the car. And so he's driving the car, and Tamerlan's in the passenger seat with his gun pointed at his head, and he's navigating them from Allston, which is— just to sort of, you know, put it on the map, so it's a little bit south and west of Cambridge. And then he's navigating them towards Watertown, which is further west of Boston.

And so— so they navigate to— and so we can assume that it was Dzhokhar who was following them behind in Dzhokhar's Civic, green Civic that we've seen from the Whole Foods footage. And he navigates them to this

address, 89 Dexter Avenue in Watertown, and this address comes up a couple times because they returned to this address three times that night.

BRACE 1:39:16

Insane!

HOWIE 1:39:18

At least that we know of, too, I mean.

BRACE 1:39:21

Yeah, these guys just keep going back to this address, which is crazy to me. I mean, again, this is one of the worst conducted crimes that we've, I think, talked about on this show.

HOWIE 1:39:33

Yeah. And so this address— Tamerlan didn't live there. He, at that point, I think, was living in the Norfolk Street apartment. Dzhokhar was living in his apartment near UMass Dartmouth. So this wasn't, like, their apartment or something.

But so anyway, so they go to this apartment, or this house, this address in Watertown, and Tamerlan gets out, and the two brothers talk, and they start loading what Dun Meng describes as heavy items into the trunk. And we'll later find out that these were pressure cooker bombs, more pressure cooker bombs, and a Tupperware bomb.

BRACE 1:40:16

Actually, Tupperware did put out a— yeah, Tupperware does— I want to be clear here because I don't want Tupperware to come after us. Tupperware says they were not Tupperware products, that I believe they were Rubbermaid. Yeah, Rubbermaid. It was a Rubbermaid, but

Tupperware-style container, we should say. Yes. I do want to debunk that a little bit with, you know, it was not necessarily Tupperware, although, frankly, show me the bomb. How does Tupperware know that?

LIZ 1:40:57

So wait, really quick, I just want to go back. So MIT is where Sean Collier was shot, which is in Cambridge. They go from Cambridge to Allston, which is like— I mean, and then from there, they go to Watertown. It doesn't seem to make a lot of sense for why they would make that trip.

HOWIE 1:41:22

Yeah, so there's some weird stuff about, you know— it's not very well reported, but Tamerlan supposedly had called one of his friends who he had actually boxed with in between the time that they set the bomb off and in between these, you know, three-day gap. He'd actually boxed with this guy and hung out with him, and supposedly what I've read is that this guy lived, like, around the corner from where the carjacking happened.

LIZ 1:41:54

Okay.

BEN 1:41:55

There— there are several random coincidences like this in the carjacking timeline where they end up in places that are very near— I mean, Boston's a small town, you know, so it's possible that it's just a coincidence, but there are several of these where they end up in a place that's very close to someone that we know they associated with and they may

have been in contact with.

HOWIE 1:42:15
But, but yeah, but I definitely agree with you, Liz. I mean, it doesn't, it's, it's— it doesn't make any sense, like, you know, why they would have gone here otherwise. So, I mean, you know, is it a coincidence? I mean, I don't know why the hell they would have been over there anyways. So, yeah.

BRACE 1:42:31
They're just bouncing around Beantown.

BEN 1:42:33
Because presumably if they're going to 89 Dexter— we don't know if they got whatever those bombs were, like, from the 89 Dexter address, or if they got— if maybe they were in Dzhokhar's trunk. But if they were going to 89 Dexter for some reason, why would they go into Allston to hijack a car? Like, it doesn't— it's— there's not really a reason that they would have done— it's out of the way, is basically what— definitely, yeah, absolutely. Yeah, it's definitely not the most direct route, that's for sure.

BRACE 1:42:57
And, like, why they were just going to kill a, like, a cop to, I guess, get his gun, you know? Like, it doesn't, you know, it— there's no real explanation for that. And then just giving up on getting the gun, like— yeah.

HOWIE 1:43:10
So that's interesting, too, because the official story is, is literally that they were going to get the gun

from the cop, which makes no sense. And, you know, another weird coincidence— Ben, I think you know about this— the lab, the MIT lab that was near.

BEN 1:43:27

Yeah, right. So Daniel Morley, who people— you know, people, as we mentioned, Daniel Morley may have been involved in that 7-Eleven robbery, and people who know him have identified him as being the person who was in that surveillance footage of that robbery. So he had been, I think he was a veterinarian tech of some kind, or he was some kind of lab tech, and he worked in that MIT Stata building that was right there where Sean Collier was killed.

So if Morley was an accomplice of theirs or was involved with them in some way, it seems possible that maybe, and McPhee mentions this, that possibly they were going to pick something up from that lab, where they were perhaps meeting Morley there for some reason, and that's why they were over there. And, you know, now as to how they ended up shooting Sean Collier doesn't make much sense, but that, that may be an explanation for why they were over there. Because I agree, it doesn't seem like shooting a cop is the— is the cleanest, fastest way to get a gun.

BRACE 1:44:23

No, definitely not. And especially considering some of the characters these guys hung out with, right? They had no problem getting a gun.

BEN 1:44:30

Yeah.

BRACE 1:44:30

They already had a gun— gun from their friend. Yeah. And, you know, I— not to, like, be like, you know, a lot of— but a lot of the guys I hung out with had guns, or at least access to people who, who had guns, who would be a lot easier to kill than a police officer if they were just going that route. I mean, it could be that they were under the influence of a certain MIT-based anarchist anti-police guy who I think maybe deserves a watchful— also known associate of Jeffrey Epstein, who shall remain unnamed.

But yeah, I mean, it doesn't make a lot of sense. So they're driving. We're back in Dun Meng's Mercedes right now, and we got these boys— he's driving these boys around. I think eventually Tamerlan gets in the front seat, right? Like, Tamerlan is driving.

HOWIE 1:45:16

Yeah. So after they— so Meng says that they put these heavy items in the trunk, what we later find out are the bombs, more bombs. At that point, Tamerlan and Meng switch places. So Tamerlan's driving and Meng is in the front seat, and Dzhokhar is in the back seat.

And so apparently, you know, again, the first thing that Tamerlan says to Dun Meng, according to Meng, is he asks him for money, and he doesn't really have very much on him. So they take him to a Bank of America ATM in Watertown, and there's footage of them at the ATM around a little after

midnight, and Dzhokhar gets out and he uses the debit card and his PIN to withdraw some cash. And then they go back to Dexter Avenue again, 89 Dexter Avenue. Jesus Christ. I don't know what they're doing.

And then at some point they start driving east from Watertown towards Cambridge. Now, very important to point out, this is sort of where this idea of the New York City bombings comes in. I think they had told Dun Meng that they wanted to go to New York and blow up bombs in Times Square. There is the Mass State Pike that is basically the quickest way to go from where they were to New York City. There's a highway literally with an on-ramp in Watertown that would have taken them west to New York City. But instead of taking that, they go east to Cambridge.

BEN 1:46:45

Back to where they are alleged to— I mean, they're going back in the direction of where they are alleged to have killed an MIT police—

LIZ 1:46:50

Like, they're going back to where all the local cops are investigating a cop shooting. Yes. Away from the freeway entrance that would take them to, allegedly, where their next bombing site is. That's right.

BRACE 1:47:04

Okay. Now, I'm no, you know, mid-century Parisian cat burglar, but I do know a thing or two about not going towards where there's a lot of police. And I gotta say, I'm a little confused at this behavior.

1:47:18

LIZ

And their faces are fully out and in the open now. Like, all the cops have the photos of these guys, and they're— I mean, they're suspected in the shooting of the cop.

1:47:28

BRACE

Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. It's, it's like kind of— well, I don't know if they are at first, but I think it's— that's— yeah, they're in the mix.

1:47:35

LIZ

It's chaos happening. It could be these guys. Yeah.

1:47:38

BEN

You know, I think that was kind of the— I don't think that they really at this point had anything that connected them, although they're later— they found, you know, ballistics evidence, et cetera, that seems to tie them to it, or at least tie the gun to it. But yeah, I think at this point, the cops were just thinking anything like this that's happening must be associated with these two guys. So certainly the police, whether they had a good reason to believe that they were involved, they did at this point think that these guys were involved in killing Sean Collier.

1:48:01

BRACE

So this caravan of death— hey, sorry, I thought that was— that sounded kinda newspaper-writery of me. This caravan of death stops at a Shell station in Cambridge, Mass. I don't know why I said Mass. Of course it's not Cambridge, England. They didn't drive that far east. This is at Memorial Drive and River Street. Do you guys

know where this is?

BEN 1:48:22
Yeah. I know that Shell station well.

HOWIE 1:48:24
Pretty much if you're going to go to Central Square from west, you drive right by it.

BRACE 1:48:29
Yeah. Yeah. And so these guys stop there. Dzhokhar, ever the stoner, goes into the convenience store and starts picking out, like, you know, potato chips, energy drinks, possibly a Monster or Rockstar. This is prior to Bang becoming, you know, very popular in the energy drink world. You know, he's got his hands full.

And Tamerlan is sitting there sort of fiddling with the GPS, which is maybe— that's why he went the wrong direction. But, you know, you'd still think these guys have lived around this area for a long time. They— and they've been to New York before. Like, you know, it's not like they didn't know how to get there. But Tamerlan's fucking with the GPS, and I guess he puts the gun down, which is— by the way, if you're ever reversed in this position, if you're ever holding someone at gunpoint, number one rule: always have the gun in the hand. Never put it down. Never help them with something. Just always have a gun and try to point it at them and stand a little bit away.

Anyways, he puts the gun down, and Dun Meng sees his chance, unbuckles his shit stealthily, and hops out of the car and sprint across the street, I think, to a different— or, like, a— I

think a couple, maybe a block or two away, actually, to a— to another gas—

BEN 1:49:40
It's right across the street.

BRACE 1:49:41
Okay, yeah. So he just goes into the gas station across the street, and there's footage of him, like, running and hiding behind the counter, be like, "Call the fucking police! Call the police! Call the police!" Which they do, and he reports that he's been carjacked by, by the Boston bombers.

LIZ 1:49:58
Now, okay, so all this happens, chaos. What do the brothers do? They go back to 89 Dexter. They go back to Watertown. Yeah.

BRACE 1:50:11
It's— I truly cannot figure out why they keep going to fucking Watertown.

LIZ 1:50:18
Well, yeah.

BRACE 1:50:21
But, yeah, they are— they drive back to Watertown, and they start getting tailed by a police officer. And I believe the way this actually starts is they're stopped by the cop and then get out and start firing at the cop. A bunch of backup comes, and there is a huge fucking gun battle. I mean, this thing is— I think they only have one gun, right? Like, these guys do not have an arsenal.

BEN 1:50:51

The story is that— I mean, officially they had one gun, but there are cops who say that they saw two guns. Now, what does that count for? But that is what a lot of the cops were on the scene say.

LIZ 1:51:01

There's multiple cop testimony. Like, there's multiple different cops that say that they saw two different muzzle flashes, that it wasn't just one gun.

BRACE 1:51:12

Yeah, and, you know, I'm sort of neutral on this, you know, like I'm like— because, you know, muzzle flash, if it's dark out, you know, any sort of, like, light in the distance— like, if you shoot something and, like, you know, it creates, you know, the kinetic force of it, like, hitting the ground or something, that can create, like, a light. You might think that's a muzzle flash. But certainly there are a lot of shots fired, about 210 shots fired.

Tamerlan at one point is standing in the middle of the street just firing and blasting, which, I gotta say, is a wild move to do. And he is just like— I mean, this is going on for eight minutes. The brothers are throwing— the cops describe them as M-80s, which it seems a little insulting— but they're, they're, they're throwing M-80s. Eventually, they throw something much larger. This is what the police say is another pressure cooker bomb.

One of the policemen, who's 28 years old, died a year later from a brain aneurysm, possibly. The blast could

have contributed to that, although— because 28 is pretty fucking young. Brain aneurysm is my worst fucking nightmare. But the important thing is that the bombs that they throw, or the bomb that they throw, does not seem like a remote detonation bomb, right?

HOWIE 1:52:31
Yeah, that's right. They were, they were just a simple fuse bomb.

BRACE 1:52:34
And this is sort of the most— the cops start running out of bullets. Tamerlan starts just, like, walking down the street and firing at them. His gun— I mean, they don't know, but his gun either jams or he runs out of ammo, but he throws the gun at them, which, by the way, also another classic movie move, is the gun-stop, like, John Wick-ass move, throwing the gun at the guy. And then he takes off running. One of the cops chases after him— mm-hmm— and tackles him, pinning him to the ground. A bunch of other cops kind of jump on top of him in a scrum. Dzhokhar gets behind the wheel of the Mercedes and starts driving towards them. By the way, Tamerlan has been shot several times at this point, too.

LIZ 1:53:16
I believe way more than— like, the scene, if you read the testimony or listen to some of the cops give the testimony of the shootout, it is so fucking nutty. Like, it is— you mentioned John Wick, it seriously sounds like this. Like, when I said Tamerlan went beast mode, it's like he gets out of the car, he has his fucking, like, arm out, just walking like he doesn't give a fuck, straight

into cops firing at him. He gets shot something like nine times and is still shooting at these guys. Yeah. Just like, it just seems like a total, like, a movie set. I mean, it's completely, completely insane.

BRACE 1:53:53

Yeah, and he is, like, on the ground, shot a bunch of times, all these cops on him, he's still trying to fight 'em off. Dzhokhar is now gunning the Mercedes down the street towards them. The cops jump— I mean, you know, I'm not— who knows what actually happened here, but the cops say that they get off of Tamerlan and try to drag him to safety. Tamerlan is just fully run over by Dzhokhar, just like a bag of laundry. Dzhokhar takes off in the car.

This is sort of where our brothers' stories diverge, although Tamerlan's ends shortly after this. Tamerlan is taken into an ambulance, where he's taken to the hospital and pronounced dead, I think, pretty shortly after arriving. I mean, the guy has been just plugged full of holes.

LIZ 1:54:44

Well, the Mercedes, too. Like, I mean, he gets caught under the wheel of the Mercedes and dragged for some time. Yeah. On the pavement, it's— there's— I mean, I've read that he may be— like, this is, this is a horrible thing to say, I don't know how else to say it, but, like, was scalped by the Mercedes. Like, I mean, it's like a— it's a gory, gory scene.

BRACE 1:55:04
Yeah, you always want to keep the scalp on. One of the most important parts of the head.

LIZ 1:55:07
Yeah, just like— yeah, Dzhokhar ended up dragging his brother, like, by the car, just like, I don't know, to his death, basically.

BRACE 1:55:16
Yeah, yeah. Which is another sort of movie-type thing that happens here. That is not that common of an occurrence. The cops also probably shot one of the other cops, too. Liz, remember the Chris Dorner episode, when we were talking about them shooting those two women, how the cops are just firing at each other? That's also kind of where I think they might have thought there were more multiple muzzle flashes coming from, because cops love to shoot at other cops and say they're getting shot at by criminals.

BEN 1:55:44
That happened here too. I think two Mass State Police officers were driving an unmarked vehicle, and some other cops started shooting at them because somehow that vehicle became a— you know, there was, like, a be-on-the-lookout for this car for some reason. So that happened several times, that there's these kinds of friendly fire incidents. So I agree. It seems, like, possible that there was just cops shooting at each other. I mean, because they basically had this whole area surrounded by the end of the gunfight.

1:56:08

BRACE

Well, the crazy thing is, is by the time the gunfight's over, and, like, in the intervening minutes after that, 1,000 cops are in Watertown. I don't know if you guys have ever seen the Batman movie that has Bane in it, but you know when they all go into the sewers? Which, by the way, rookie move. Never go into any sewers under any circumstance, unless you're a sewer guy.

1:56:30

LIZ

Yeah, that's like— yeah.

1:56:32

BRACE

It's like— it's like all— every mole man in Boston, the greater Beantown area, is descended onto Watertown. Somehow Dzhokhar still gets away, despite being in, like, a shot-up Mercedes, stolen Mercedes, one of the only cars driving around, with, like, his brother's scalp going around in the wheel well. The FBI for some reason does not, like, center on his actual, like, last known location, but back to where he actually ran over his brother. So, like, he's in a car, he's moving, but they're like, "Well, we'll start actually at the scene of the shootout."

He drives for around two minutes before he ditches the SUV. And the BPD, which, by the way— I cannot believe there's an all-female police department. All-girlfriend police department, no less. No, the Boston Police Department shows up, and they got all these dogs and shit, you know? They're like, "We're gonna catch this guy." FBI is like, "No, we got it. You know, it's— you don't need your— fuck,

we don't need your little fucking hounds here. Like, we can figure this girl— this guy is on our own." Wrong.

Dzhokhar goes into this guy's, David Henneberry's, backyard, and poor David here— David's got a boat in dry dock, and by that I mean, like, probably just on some stilts or whatever. I don't know how you hold boats in a backyard, but, you know, there's boats in the guy's backyard. Dzhokhar slips underneath the little canvas covering there and down into the bowels of this sailboat, where he basically curls up. And this is— Ben, you— you— I want to, I want to hand this to you, because you— I know you have some questions about what happens in that boat.

BEN 1:58:17

Well, this is the thing, is that Dzhokhar allegedly— and it becomes a key— well, not again, like, not allegedly anymore, because he's been convicted— according to the government, he writes this, essentially, what— and the thing is, it's taken to be a confession, and if you actually read it, it isn't really a confession. You can read it that way. Yeah. But according to the government, he scrawls— he, like, scratches into the wood— it was, like, wood paneling on this boat— he scratches this long message.

But the thing is, at this point, Dzhokhar has been shot through the face. He has a huge cut on his neck. He's bleeding heavily. And he has the foresight to not only scratch this message out, but then apparently uses a fire extinguisher, sprays the fire extinguisher at this message that he scratched, so that now, like, the

space that he's scratched out becomes filled with the fire extinguisher powder, essentially, so it's more visible.

The idea that he did this and confessed, essentially— I mean, again, you can read it as not a confession, but according to the government, it was essentially a confession, and that's the way it was used, and it became a crucial piece of evidence in the trial that convicted him, that he wrote this— that according to the government, he wrote this message while he was laying in there as, like, a last will and testament, essentially, because I think he assumed he was going to die at that point. He was basically bleeding out.

BRACE 1:59:49
Yeah, he got his ass shot up.

BEN 1:59:51
Yeah, he didn't have any— I don't think he had an escape plan at this point. And yeah, I forgot this, he also had a skull fracture at this point. So I just don't, I just don't— it doesn't seem credible to me that he is the person that wrote this. It really seems to me, the way that I read this, it seems planted.

LIZ 2:00:12
So what does the message say?

HOWIE 2:00:15
It says something like, you know, "Stop killing our innocents and we'll stop killing yours." Yeah. It's tough to make out.

LIZ 2:00:25
Well, there's a lot of it that's illegible.

HOWIE 2:00:29
Yeah, a lot of it's riddled with bullet holes. But one of the things that's interesting is that it's used as— I mean, like Ben mentioned, it's used in the trial. But it's also— it's basically the official narrative as far as the motive for the bombing, that it was done by radical, you know, jihadi Muslims.

BRACE 2:00:54
Yeah, in order to sort of avenge the death of Muslims at American hands overseas. Yeah.

BEN 2:01:01
But the thing is, when you actually read it, because the— for instance, because Dzhokhar says in this, you know, "I'm jealous of my brother, who's received the reward"— you know, he's been killed, so he's received the reward of heaven, inshallah, before me. "God has a plan for each person. Mine was to hide in this boat and shed some light on our actions." And the thing is that that statement is taken to refer to the bomb, including the bombings, you know, everything.

But you could also read this as just this carjacking that's happened. And for instance, if you think that— I certainly don't think they had nothing to do with what happened. But for instance, if you think that they were essentially picked as the patsies from among the people who were involved in this, and then they decide they need to get the hell out of Dodge because

they're now part of this investigation, you can see how this is a confused kid who has no clue what the fuck is going on. He's been involved in this carjacking now. And so he's trying to— like, even assuming that he is the one that wrote this, it doesn't seem like it actually has anything to do with the bombing at all, if you just read it as what it's written.

But again, it was interpreted by— certainly by the prosecution, and I think by the jurors— as being essentially, you know, that statement of, you know, "I shed some light on our actions." I think that was taken by everybody as, as meaning, we did the bombings. Like, that's taken as a confession, but I don't really think that it is.

So I just have a lot of questions about this, about this supposed— about this supposed confession that he wrote, because it really is— and as, as Howie mentioned, this becomes the motive. But if you, for instance, read, you know, Michele McPhee's book, her strong implication— and this is something we'll get to with Tamerlan— but her strong implication is that Tamerlan did this because he was essentially denied U.S. citizenship that he was promised in return for services he rendered to the FBI, presumably. So that has nothing to do with, you know, radical Islam or jihad. That is just somebody not getting paid for a job they did and getting pissed off, right? And I don't know that that's actually the motive, but it just seems like there's these conflicting motives, and you can't really square them. And I don't think

that this statement really actually sheds much light on— on certainly not on what happened at the bombing.

BRACE 2:03:28

To be clear, both Tamerlan and, you know, their mother, Zubeidat, don't even believe the 9/11 bombing was done by Muslims. You know, it was— they, they, they, they— it's not like he was, you know, even— even the, you know, taking the story totally at face value. Okay? Like, these people were not inspired by 9/11, because they don't believe that their team, or whatever in this case, did 9/11. They thought the United States government did that. Or, well, they kind of leave it unclear who they actually think did it, but they do not think that it was done by the people who were officially blamed for it.

Well, you know, Tamerlan— or excuse me, Dzhokhar's in the boat for a while, which has, by the way, got to be terrifying and really shitty, because you're basically just bleeding out and dying at the bottom of the boat. Henneberry had sort of glimpsed outside. By the way, the neighborhood's totally on lockdown. You're not allowed to leave your house, like, go to your backyard, do anything. You are staying inside your house.

Henneberry does glance outside at his backyard. I mean, a boat guy, God bless him. You know, he's probably like, "Well, I can't get a way to get out there and crab, get some fucking— get some lobsters." And, you know, he glances out long— I'm going to say, I'm going to editorialize here and say he glances longingly at his boat,

wishing he was out there on the Atlantic, just him and his boys and some nets. And he sees that the tarp is a little messed up. He's like, "Huh, I wonder what happened there." Possibly some gales, a nor'easter, maybe. But, you know, he's a little suspicious. Like, "I'll let sleeping dogs lie. Once they lift the stay-at-home order, I'll go check it out."

And around 6 p.m., Henneberry does go out, and he opens up— he lifts up the tarp, and then he sees little Dzhokhar curled up on the floor of the boat, bleeding out and dying. He's like, "Well, okay." And he just took the tarp back down, and he goes back inside, and he calls the police. The police come— huge police and FBI showing, SWAT teams lining the place up, you know, fucking everyone's sighted in, different teams, like, all tactically ready and stuff like that.

They throw some flashbangs. Now, this is a little important, because they throw flashbangs, and it's warned, "We're going to throw some flashbangs." Any sort of loud bang like that— those things are loud as fuck— but that might sound like gunfire to somebody who's not right next to them, and that could lead you to opening fire. The warning goes out, "We are throwing—" and— flashbangs. Doesn't matter. Immediately one of the cops starts opening fire, and then everybody joins in, and a fusillade is unleashed. A broadside, let's say. It's a boat. A broadside is unleashed against this boat. The police fire 126 shots in 10 seconds. There is zero return fire from the boat.

Dzhokhar was shot a number of times. I actually couldn't get a full count of times, how many bullets actually hit him, but he was shot, I think, both legs, in the face, in the jaw, one of his hands, and in his throat. He is sort of— there's footage of him emerging from the boat that I— I mean, he— I think he's actually even on his own, walking on his own. Yeah.

BEN 2:06:43
He managed to stand. Yeah.

BRACE 2:06:44
Yeah, which is crazy, because even if I'm just sleepy, sometimes that's hard for me. He must have been really sleepy. You know, he walks out of the boat and he is arrested. And at the same time, the police are also going around and basically arresting— because they, they— I mean, now everybody knows these guys' names. You know, their identities are fully established. And they're basically arresting every single person who knows.

HOWIE 2:07:24
Yeah. And so that— so he was found at around, around 6 p.m., and that was the next day after that shooting happened overnight. Is that right? Yeah. So he spent— he spent— he was in the boat for a long time.

BRACE 2:07:39
Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. I imagine sort of drifting in and out of consciousness. But yeah, the police also— that's when the police sort of, you know, get the Tupperware bomb— or excuse me, the Rubbermaid bomb— from the back of the SUV, kind of collect other things.

Officially, there is one nine-millimeter pistol that they collect, and a BB gun, which I— sort of makes me sad to imagine this, even though it probably didn't actually happen. It's like Tamerlan has the real gun and he gives Dzhokhar the BB gun to fire the police with. But although I imagine actually they just bought a BB gun and so they could have BBs, or someone bought a BB gun, and there were BBs possibly for the pressure cooker bomb.

But at this point, you know, one of the brothers isn't dead— and the other is dead, and the other is in custody, possibly going to die. You know, he's pretty shot up. And, you know, this is kind of— I feel like this, this really— that's kind of it. That's the end.

BEN 2:08:34

I mean, it literally is, like, case closed at this point. Like, this guy scrawled his apparent confession. The other brother is dead. And, you know, these are the only two people who possibly could have been involved in this. Exactly. And so that's it.

LIZ 2:08:47

Yeah, and Boston remains strong.

BRACE 2:08:50

Yeah, I mean, this is when Boston Strong really debuted. I mean, with the— with the— I mean, well, it literally did debut with this, but this is when a lot of people started looking at how they were going to make a bunch of T-shirt money.

HOWIE 2:09:02

Yeah, it was the second biggest tragedy since, you know, the day that the planes took off from Boston Logan Airport on 9/11.

BEN 2:09:11

Yeah, yeah, yeah, exactly. Or the Great Molasses Flood. I mean, that would be the other big one that I would point to. I mean, this is really like— after that, you know, this is the big one.

LIZ 2:09:22

Well, I feel like in this episode, what we wanted to do was kind of lay out the timeline to show not just, like, how much missing information there is, like, even still, nine years later, with a lot of reporting, a full trial, a lot of appeals to that trial, and plenty of books, that there's still a lot of pretty, I would say, important and kind of cut-to-the-heart-of-this-case questions that remain unanswered, both when we talk about motive, but also when we talk about the agencies involved in the manhunt, in the investigation that happened the week after the bombing, and even in the bombing itself, right?

But we opened the episode talking about, you know, FBI informants, and we, in classic TrueAnon fashion, we kind of didn't mention any of that through the episode. So I'm going to mention it now, is that it's pretty clear, as we're going to talk about the next episode, that Tamerlan was an FBI informant.

BEN 2:10:30

At the very least, and possibly also a CIA informant, and possibly also part of some kind of joint operation with Russian internal security as well. It seems very, very possible.

BRACE 2:10:41

A true Renaissance man, as it was. I mean, the established facts that we do know, literally, I mean, point us to his uncle being married to the daughter of a pretty prominent CIA analyst and a man who is very active in the region of the world that these people come from.

But beyond that, even, is that this case extends far— just, it is— it is— there is— there is a lot more death. In fact, there are more deaths involved in the, let's say, lead-up to this case and Tamerlan's activities in the year or years prior to this case than there are actually in the Boston bombing itself. You know, the, the, the, the people that the Tsarnaev brothers associated with— let me tell you, if you are friends with Dzhokhar or Tamerlan in the years leading up to the Boston bombing, there is 100% of a chance that you've been to prison because of that and are now deported to Dagestan or Kyrgyzstan or Russia. If you were friends with Tamerlan Tsarnaev in the two years prior to the Boston bombing, there is almost a 100% chance that you were either killed and you had your dick chopped off, or that you were murdered by, or killed in an anti-terror operation by Russian special forces or a CIA wet work team.

There's a lot more to this story than possibly the movie— what's the fucking Marky Mark movie? Patriots Day.

Patriots Day. We were going to watch that and we didn't.

BEN 2:12:21

Next show.

BRACE 2:12:21

We were going to do it, too. And then I just watched the trailer. Listen, I— this is the trailer, like 10 minutes before we were going to record, to get this pumped up. And it's like, I knew— I was like, I meant to watch this. And there's also a Jake Gyllenhaal— no, Jared Leto— or Jake Gyllenhaal one, too, about the guy who got his legs blown off.

But yeah, there is a lot more to this story, and— but I feel like today we just had to establish the basic facts of— or not even facts, but the general timeline of what happened, in order for us to— well, that's a foundation upon which we will build our case. So with that—

LIZ 2:13:07

I'm Liz.

BRACE 2:13:08

My name, of course, is Brace. I was trying to think of something cool to say, but I can't.

BEN 2:13:14

I'm Ben.

HOWIE 2:13:15

I'm Howie.

BRACE 2:13:16

And of course, we're joined by producer Young Chomsky, MIT professor— MIT producer Young Chomsky. And the podcast is called Tsarn— TrueAnon.

2:13:27

LIZ
And we'll see you next time. Bye-bye.